Wahkiakum Common Ground 2026

FINAL REPORT

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2. Wahkiakum County Marine Resources Committee
3. Wahkiakum Conservation District
4. Chinook Indian Nation
5. Pacific Conservation District
6. Washington State University Extension
7. Cowlitz-Wahkiakum Council of Governments
8. Washington Sea Grant, COHORT
9. Lower Columbia Fish Recovery Board

Executive Summary

The Wahkiakum Common Ground 2026 Workshop series consisted of four workshops that provided opportunities for connection between local residents, representatives of agencies, organizations, and tribes; education on watershed restoration and flood mitigation; and discussion of future resilience-building efforts. The goal of these workshops was primarily to help build relationships and shared understanding - the common ground - that is needed for collaborative multi-benefit adaptation projects.

These workshops were led by the Wahkiakum County Marine Resources Committee with funding from the Cascadia Coastlines and Peoples Hazards Research Hub. The workshops were held between January and May of 2026, with the following themes:

- Cultural, Ecological, and Economic Significance of Restoring Watersheds
- Restoring and Managing Salmon in Wahkiakum Streams
- Mitigating Flooding in Wahkiakum's Tidal Stream Reaches
- Living Behind Dikes in Wahkiakum County

Wahkiakum Common Ground visits the Grays River Covered Bridge.
Photo by Jenna Tilt

Each workshop included multiple guest presentations, a visit to a relevant project site to showcase successes in the county, and group discussions to reflect and identify strengths in the county and priority topics that participants could help move forward.

The Wahkiakum Common Ground 2026 Series led to:

- Increased awareness of flood mitigation initiatives in the county
- Greater awareness of the multiple benefits of watershed restoration projects for fish and people
- Increased understanding of coastal hazards by community residents
- More relationships and connections
- Identification of eight priority topics that can be supported or led by Wahkiakum Common Ground participants

This report details the motivations for these workshops, the design of the workshops, the guest presentations, site visits, group discussions, outcomes from the workshop, and lessons learned.

Table of Contents

i. Acknowledgements

The workshop series would not have been possible without the generous support, collaboration, and contributions of many individuals and organizations.

We gratefully acknowledge our funder, the Cascadia Coastlines and Peoples Hazards Research Hub, whose support made this work possible.

We extend our sincere appreciation to our guest speakers and site visit leaders, who generously shared their knowledge, expertise, and experiences (alphabetically by last name): Tony Aegerter, Brooke Bennett, Jackson Blalock, Andy Bookter, Jerry Bowden, Commissioner Dan Cothren, Donny Dyer, Bryce Glaser, Darin Houpt, Jay Horita, Chairman Tony Johnson, Amelia Johnson, Judy Johnson, Irene Martin, Ian Sinks, Austin Smith, and Todd Souvenir. We are grateful to them and their organizations for the time, insight, and leadership they contributed to the series.

We appreciate the Chinook Indian Nation and Cowlitz Indian Tribe for their knowledge, perspective, example, and leadership in conserving natural resources.

A sincere thank you to WSU Extension supporting staff Shari Parker and Jessica Vik for the many ways they worked behind the scenes to ensure everything ran smoothly. From organizing materials and preparing coffee and snacks to cleaning up, taking photographs, and supporting countless logistical details, their efforts were essential to the success of the workshops.

We also acknowledge Washington State's Coastal Hazards Organizational Resilience Team (COHORT) for their partnership, guidance, and continued commitment to strengthening coastal resilience efforts. We appreciate the support that Sam Giannakos, Ellen Chappelka, Sanpisa Sritrairat, and Olivia Zimmerman gave.

To all of the participants in this workshop series, thank you for your thoughtful engagement, reflection, and contributions of time, energy, and ideas. Your willingness to share experiences, ask questions, and learn alongside one another enriched every aspect of the series.

Thank you to the Planning Team for your time, thoughtful ideas, collaboration, and commitment throughout this process.

ii. Funding Information

Funding for this series was provided by the Cascadia Coastlines and Peoples (CoPes) Hazards Research Hub via a pilot grant. The Cascadia CoPes Hub is funded by the U.S. National Science Foundation, Award #2103713. More information on the Cascadia CoPes Hub can be found at https://cascadiacopeshub.org/.

iii. 2026 Workshop Planning Team

Listed alphabetically by last name

Brooke Bennett	Voluntary Stewardship Program Coordinator, *Wahkiakum Conservation District*
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Mary Johnson	Culture Coordinator, *Chinook Indian Nation*
Andrea Mah	Postdoctoral Scholar, Cascadia Coastlines and Peoples (CoPes) Hazards Research Hub, Oregon State University
Benjamin Newman	Marine and Estuarine Resilience Project Manager, *Pacific Conservation District*
Carrie Shofner	Wahkiakum County Director and Associate Professor, Washington State University (WSU) Extension; Coordinator, Wahkiakum County Marine Resources Committee
Samuel Shogren	Chair, Wahkiakum County Marine Resources Committee; Community Development Planner II, Cowlitz-Wahkiakum Council of Governments
Sanpisa Sritrairat	Community Engagement Specialist, Washington Sea Grant, Coastal Organizational Hazards Resilience Team
Sandra Staples-Bortner	Vice Chair, Wahkiakum County Marine Resources Committee; Member, Lower Columbia Fish Recovery Board
Jenna Tilt	Associate Professor, Cascadia Coastlines and Peoples Hazards Research Hub, Oregon State University
Steve West	Habitat Policy Specialist, Lower Columbia Fish Recovery Board

1. Introduction

1.1 Project Background

For communities to successfully respond to and prepare for hazards, they must implement adaptation and mitigation projects that require significant funding and coordination among stakeholders. Building a shared understanding of the benefits of these projects is important for their long-term success. Wahkiakum County is a rural community with natural resource-based economies (timber, salmon, and agriculture) severely impacted by chronic coastal-driven hazards like flooding and erosion, as well as imperiled salmon that are listed under the federal Endangered Species Act (ESA) as “threatened” with extinction. This ESA classification is one step below the more severe “endangered” status that the region hopes to avoid. These twin threats–life-altering hazards and decimated salmon streams–create new opportunities for funding of watershed restoration projects that can simultaneously address hazards to fish and people. However, these solutions are often met with resistance, in part due to lack of engagement and trust among stakeholders.

In order to increase engagement and trust among stakeholders, Wahkiakum Common Ground 2026 sought to build on the engagement approach used in the Wahkiakum Common Ground Workshop Series for Leaders (2025), to respond to needs identified in that workshop series and the *Bay to Bay Lower Columbia River Resilience Workshops*[1]. The 2025 workshop series convened community leaders and representatives of local and regional agencies, tribes and organizations to participate in four half-day workshops. These workshops included educational presentations on successful collaborations, visits to project sites, and group discussions. More detail on these workshops, and their motivation is provided in the *Wahkiakum Common Ground Workshop Series: Final Report* (October, 2025) and at https://beav.es/WCG. At the conclusion of the 2025 series, attendees were interested in continuing the workshops, and wanted to increase engagement of county residents in future workshops.

In Summer of 2025, the Wahkiakum Common Ground planning team applied for and received funding from the Cascadia CoPes Hub to continue workshops in 2026. The proposal outlined a pilot project to conduct additional workshops focused on coastal hazards education and evaluate those workshops. More detail on the evaluation and the research goals of the pilot proposal is provided in 1.4.1.

In December 2025, while planning for the 2026 series was already underway, Wahkiakum County was exposed to severe storms, winds, and flooding, resulting in a Federal Declaration of Disaster (https://www.fema.gov/disaster/3629). Incorporating discussion of coastal hazards was already planned for the workshops and these December 2025 floods underscored the need for community discussion around mitigation measures.

1.2 Workshop Series Vision & Goals

The goals of the 2026 workshops built on those identified for the 2025 series, with additions to those goals bolded: The workshops sought to convene county, regional, special district, state, tribal, nonprofit, and community leaders, **and local residents** to learn about and discuss successful watershed restoration and **flood mitigation projects** in order to increase understanding of ways to use funding for fish-friendly

[1] https://wacoastalnetwork.com/bay-to-bay-community-based-coastal-resilience-action/

upgrades to achieve multiple benefits, document assets and resources crucial to project success, and find common goals and priorities foundational to future efforts to improve the resilience of the county. The working vision of the series was to build a Wahkiakum County that respects the past, thrives in the present, and adapts to future challenges by using a collaborative community-focused approach that fosters a healthy environment, rural lifestyle, and vibrant economy. The Common Ground priorities were:

- reduce the impacts of flooding and erosion on private property and public infrastructure,
- restore local watersheds that support abundant salmon and natural resources,
- improve community resilience to natural hazards and long-term social, environmental, and economic changes, and
- boost the economic vitality of Wahkiakum County.

1.3 Project Sponsors and Partners

The Wahkiakum Common Ground workshops are co-produced by representatives from multiple organizations, each bringing their own expertise and resources.

Wahkiakum County Marine Resources Committee (MRC) led this project as a county-based volunteer group composed of economic, conservation, recreational, and community interests and government agencies established in 2008 by the Wahkiakum County Commissioners as part of the Washington Department of Fish and Wildlife Coastal Marine Resources Committee (Coastal MRC) Program. The mission of the Wahkiakum County Marine Resources Committee is to "*engage and educate the residents of Wahkiakum County in stewarding this place we call home. Our goals are to strengthen community and ecosystem resilience, build partnerships, and support marine livelihoods.*" The Wahkiakum MRC is coordinated by WSU Wahkiakum County Extension under a contract with Wahkiakum County and funding from Washington Department of Fish and Wildlife.

Washington State University (WSU) Wahkiakum County Extension is the local arm of Washington State University's land-grant mission in Wahkiakum County, with joint support by WSU and Wahkiakum County, providing community-driven research and education. https://extension.wsu.edu/wahkiakum/

The Cascadia Coastlines and Peoples Hazards Research Hub (Cascadia CoPes Hub) is a National Science Foundation–funded collaboration among Oregon State University, University of Washington, Cal Poly Humboldt, and University of Oregon. The CoPes Hub seeks to advance science about natural hazards and climate change risks faced by coastal communities. The Hub works to conduct co-produced research with and for Cascadia coastal communities, including providing grants for pilot projects such as this workshop series. Representatives of Team 3 in the Hub which focuses on community adaptive capacity, participated in planning of Wahkiakum Common Ground. https://cascadiacopeshub.org

Lower Columbia Fish Recovery Board (LCFRB) coordinates implementation of the Washington Lower Columbia Salmon Recovery and Fish & Wildlife Subbasin Plan for Endangered Species Act listed salmon and steelhead. They work with partners across southwest Washington to address and fund habitat restoration to return salmon and steelhead to healthy and harvestable levels. https://lcfrb.org/

Coastal Hazards Organizational Resilience Team (COHORT) is an interagency team established to enhance the resilience of Washington's coastal communities and Tribes. The team brings together expertise from the Washington State Department of Ecology (Ecology), Washington Sea Grant (WSG), Washington State University Extension (WSU Extension), and Washington State Emergency Management Division (EMD). COHORT works collaboratively with coastal Washington communities and Tribes on the identification, co-creation, and implementation of resilience projects, planning efforts, and other capacity-building activities, addressing risks such as flooding, erosion, sea level rise, and other coastal challenges. https://wacoastalnetwork.com/cohort/

Washington Sea Grant (WSG) is part of the National Sea Grant College Program, housed at the College of the Environment at the University of Washington. The WSG mission is to help people and marine life thrive by supporting research, technical expertise and educational activities that foster the responsible use and conservation of ocean and coastal ecosystems. WSG supports a culture of scientific integrity and serves as a trusted source of place-based information and real-world expertise that honors the history, people and places of Washington. https://wsg.washington.edu/

Pacific Conservation District (PCD) assists landowners, jurisdictions, tribes, and other entities with voluntary technical assistance and project support related to natural resource concerns. PCD hosts the Pacific County Marine Resources Committee, which collaborates regularly with the Wahkiakum County Marine Resources Committee. Related, PCD's Marine & Estuarine Resilience Program works to support collaborative adaptation to flooding, erosion, climate change, and other changes affecting our coastal communities and ecosystems. https://pacificcd.org/

The Chinook Indian Nation (CIN) has over 3,400 enrolled members. CIN is organized to enhance the cultural, social, and economic well-being of all CIN citizens, to protect the other-than-human relatives within CIN's lands and waters, and to facilitate political and legal relationships with external governments/entities. CIN is made up of the five western-most Chinookan-speaking Tribes at the mouth of the Columbia River and adjoining sea coast including the Clatsop and Cathlamet of present-day Oregon, the Lower Chinook, Willapa, and Wahkiakum of what is now Washington State. Our contemporary tribal government was established by the leaders of our five tribes in the 1920s, prior to the Indian Reorganization Act. We have been acknowledged in federal court, as the sole heirs to the Clatsop and Lower Chinook Lands (Indian Claims Commission Docket 234 in 1970) which resulted in the compensation for stolen lands from those two territories. Our work is focused on preserving traditional lifeways and leading modern stewardship work that benefits the whole community through tribal sensibilities learned from thousands of years on the land.

The Wahkiakum Conservation District (WCD) provides technical and financial assistance to landowners to address natural resource concerns. WCD leverages local, state, and federal funding sources and serves as a hub to connect landowners with the support needed to complete project design, permitting, and construction. Examples of common projects facilitated by WCD include installing large woody debris jams to halt bank erosion and enhance fish habitat, or establishing native plant buffers to encourage healthy riparian corridors. WCD also manages the Voluntary Stewardship Program within Wahkiakum County, which focuses on the overlap of agriculture and critical areas with the goal of protecting and enhancing both. https://cowlitzcd.wordpress.com/welcome/wahkiakum-conservation-district/

1.4 Workshop Design

In 2025, the workshops used a positive engagement framework—a strength-based, collaborative approach that emphasizes assets, participation, and future-focused learning—alongside hands-on activities. Grounded in Asset-Based Community Development (Kretzmann & McKnight, 1993), they focused on learning from project impacts. Activities drew on appreciative inquiry (Cooperrider & Whitney, 2005), systems leadership (Reos Partners & The Nature Conservancy, 2024), and The Art of Hosting (Corrigan & Frost, 2025) to build collective knowledge through a participatory approach.

Wahkiakum Common Ground is premised on the idea that when locals, decision-makers, and government agencies and NGOs come together to learn more about prior successful projects, share their expertise and concerns, and get to know one another over meals and conversation, they will be more willing to work together. Building trust is a process, one that requires a history of successful interactions (Cakal et al., 2019). By holding this workshop series, the hope was that trust would increase, setting the stage for future collaboration.

Activities in the 2026 series were again informed by the literature on Appreciative inquiry and Intergroup Contact Theory. Appreciative inquiry describes a method for achieving organizational change through inquiry that focuses on positives rather than problems, using dialogue to identify existing strengths and successes, to envision what might be possible, and to work towards a shared goal. Intergroup Contact Theory (Allport, 1954) argues that the way to overcome conflict between groups (e.g., landowners, agency representatives) is to provide opportunities for those groups to meet in neutral spaces and work towards common goals, because “through meaningful, institutionally supported collaborative interactions between members from different social identity groups, prejudice will be decreased” (Young et al., 2023).

Simple contact between groups that have conflict has been shown to reduce prejudice, however, there are certain conditions of contact that tend to have stronger effects (Pettigrew & Tropp, 2006). The specific conditions that can enhance the effects of intergroup contact include contact that: involves cooperation to identify or achieve shared goals; involves perspective-taking; promotes a common in-group identity; creates equal status between groups in a neutral space; and involves high-quality contact, and multiple contact opportunities between groups (Pettigrew & Tropp, 2005; Yao et al., 2019).

Attendees at a field visit during the 2025 workshops cooperate to get a van out of the mud.
Photo by Sanpisa Sritrairat

The workshop design addressed principles of intergroup contact and appreciative inquiry:

Intergroup contact and appreciative inquiry principles	Mechanisms to achieve common ground
Perspective-taking	Experiential learning through presentations on projects and site visits with landowners, partners
Cooperating to identify or achieve shared goals	Group discussions on project benefits for people (e.g., safety, economy) and fish, identification of assets
Creating equal status between groups in a neutral space	Meetings held in community gathering spaces, group agreement to 'see a leader in every chair' to value each participant's wisdom and experience they bring to share
Involving high-quality contact, and multiple contact opportunities between groups	Attendees asked to attend all workshops in the series, each of which is five-hours long
Promoting re-categorization under a common in-group identity	Promotion of the idea of the *Common Ground* workshops as a working group, unified over shared priorities to address environmental challenges
Appreciating: using a positive (not problem-focused) lens to value strengths, envision and work towards possible futures	Presentations focused on successes. Discussions focused on the identification of strengths, and ways to leverage strengths for future efforts

To design prompts for discussion activities (Section 2.6) and to identify relevant constructs to measure in the evaluation, we referred to literature published on initiatives to engage diverse stakeholders in natural resource management [2], Appreciative Inquiry [3], intergroup contact and other social-identity

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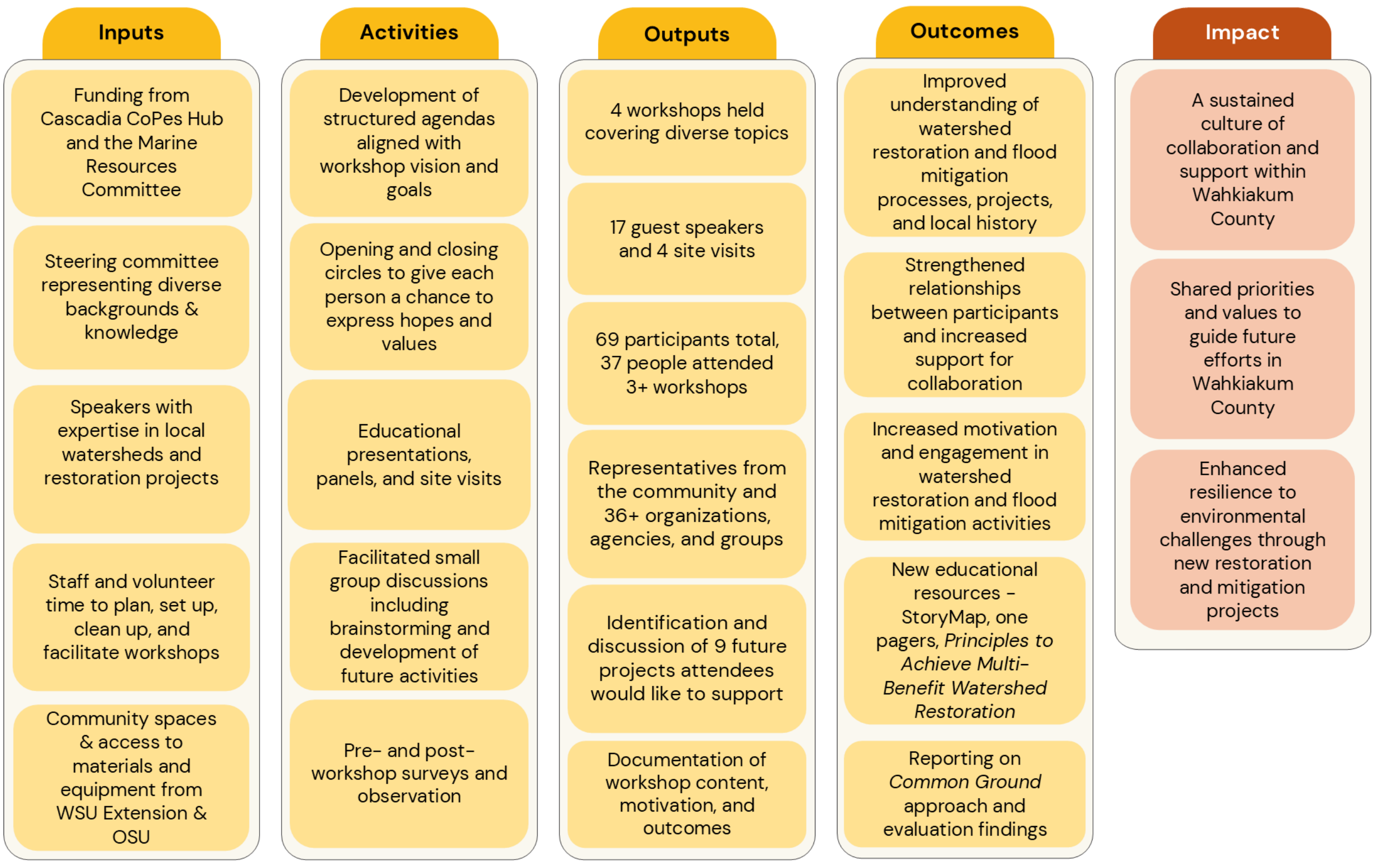
[2] E.g., Aanesen, M., Armstrong, C. W., Bloomfield, H. J., & Röckmann, C. (2014). What does stakeholder involvement mean for fisheries management? *Ecology and Society*, *19*(4). https://www.jstor.org/stable/26269676
Han, Z., Wei, Y., Bouckaert, F., Johnston, K., & Head, B. (2024). Stakeholder engagement in natural resource management: Where to go from here? *Journal of Cleaner Production*, *435*, 140521. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jclepro.2023.140521
Johansson, A. (2023). Managing Intractable Natural Resource Conflicts: Exploring Possibilities and Conditions for Reframing in a Mine Establishment Conflict in Northern Sweden. *Environmental Management*, *72*(4), 818–837. https://doi.org/10.1007/s00267-023-01838-5
Johansson, A., Lindahl, K. B., & Zachrisson, A. (2022). Exploring prospects of deliberation in intractable natural resource management conflicts. *Journal of Environmental Management*, *315*, 115205. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jenvman.2022.115205
Taylor, B. M. (2010). Between argument and coercion: Social coordination in rural environmental governance. *Journal of Rural Studies*, *26*(4), 383–393. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jrurstud.2010.05.002
[3] E.g., Bushe, G. R., & Kassam, A. F. (2005). When Is Appreciative Inquiry Transformational?: A Meta-Case Analysis. *The Journal of Applied Behavioral Science*, *41*(2), 161–181. https://doi.org/10.1177/0021886304270337
Grant, S., & Humphries, M. (2006). Critical evaluation of appreciative inquiry: Bridging an apparent paradox. *Action Research*, *4*(4), 401–418. https://doi.org/10.1177/1476750306070103

focused approaches in natural resource conflicts [4]. More detail on how the workshop design aligns with the research literature will be provided in a forthcoming paper.

The project team met regularly to plan the workshop series. Building on the design of the 2025 workshop series, workshops included opening and closing circles; educational presentations with time for question and answer; site visits; catered lunch; and group discussions on topics of multi-use adaptation, identification of priorities and the assets essential to prior successes that could be leveraged for future work. More detail on each of these types of activities is provided in section 2, and Figure 1 presents a logic model illustrating the relationships between the program's inputs, activities and the short-, medium-, and long-term outcomes they are intended to produce.

Figure 1. Logic model of the Wahkiakum Common Ground 2026 series



[4] For example: Colvin, R. M., Witt, G. B., & Lacey, J. (2015). The social identity approach to understanding socio-political conflict in environmental and natural resources management. *Global Environmental Change*, *34*, 237–246. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.gloenvcha.2015.07.011
Minato, W., Curtis, A., & Allan, C. (2010). Social Norms and Natural Resource Management in a Changing Rural Community. *Journal of Environmental Policy & Planning*, *12*(4), 381–403. https://doi.org/10.1080/1523908X.2010.531084
Schroeder, S. A., Landon, A. C., Fulton, D. C., & McInenly, L. E. (2021). Social identity, values, and trust in government: How stakeholder group, ideology, and wildlife value orientations relate to trust in a state agency for wildlife management. *Biological Conservation*, *261*, 109285. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.biocon.2021.109285

1.4.1 Evaluation

The workshop series was evaluated using pre- and post-workshop surveys and observation. Surveys were created in Qualtrics and distributed via e-mail prior to the first workshop and after the final workshop. The goal of the evaluation was to understand whether the Common Ground workshops:

- Increase awareness of organizations, number of connections, and overall social network density
- Influence perceptions of community risk and resilience for environmental challenges
- Increase sense of self- and collective efficacy to effect change
- Increase support for Common Ground priorities
- Influence support for different approaches to flooding mitigation including watershed restoration and awareness of multi-benefit adaptation
- Influence perceptions of barriers to mitigation and responsibility to address flooding

Pre- and post-workshop surveys included a set of common items to allow for comparison over time. The post-workshop survey included additional questions about experience of the workshops. The research question guiding the evaluation was: *Is this Common Ground model of engagement effective for increasing hazard awareness; knowledge of the links between restoration, mitigation, and adaptation strategies and their impacts on the environment, community, and economy; social capital; and ultimately collaborative, community-led restoration projects that mitigate hazards?*

1.4.2 Attendees

The workshop series was intended to bring together locals and tribal, agency, organization, and government representatives who had potential to participate in or support collaborative efforts to restore watersheds or support flood mitigation projects. To participate, attendees were asked to register using an online form. This form was distributed via e-mail to all participants of the 2025 workshops. The workshops were also advertised in the Wahkiakum Eagle for three weeks, see Figure 2. In addition to this, the planning team made some personal invitations to representatives of specific organizations that they hoped would be represented in the workshops.

In total, 69 people participated in at least one workshop. Twenty-seven people came to all four workshops, with another ten people attending three workshops, meaning that a majority of participants (54%) came to 3+ workshops.

Figure 2. Announcement published in the Wahkiakum Eagle

The people who attended belonged to the following 36 organizations and groups including tribes, community-based organizations and non-profits, academic institutions, state agencies, local government, and more:

- Cascadia CoPes Hub
- Cathlamet WHEELHouse
- Chinook Indian Nation
- Chinook Observer
- Coastal Organizational Hazards Resilience Team (COHORT)
- Columbia Land Trust
- Columbia River Estuary Task Force (CREST)
- Consejo Hispano
- Cowlitz Indian Tribe
- Deep River Association
- Grays River Flood Control District
- Grays River Grange
- Lower Columbia Fish Recovery Board
- Lower Columbia River Watershed Council
- Manulife Forest Management
- Necanicum Watershed Council
- Oregon Health and Science University
- Oregon State University
- Pacific Conservation District
- Shoalwater Bay Tribe
- Skamokawa Grange
- Wahkiakum Board of County Commissioners
- Wahkiakum Conservation District
- Wahkiakum County Diking District No. 1
- Wahkiakum County Diking District No. 5
- Wahkiakum County Fire District 2
- Wahkiakum County Historical Society
- Wahkiakum County Marine Resources Committee
- Wahkiakum County Noxious Weed Board
- Wahkiakum County Port District No. 1
- Washington Department of Ecology
- Washington Department of Emergency Management
- Washington Department of Fish and Wildlife
- Washington Department of Natural Resources
- Washington Sea Grant
- Washington State University Extension

Groups reflect on the site visit at Workshop 1. *Photo by Sanpisa Sritrairat*

2. Workshops

Four workshops were held:

- **Workshop 1: Cultural, Ecological, and Economic Significance of Restoring Watersheds**, January 28, 2026, 9:30 AM - 2:30 PM, Appelo Annex
    - 42 attendees
    - Site Visit: Elochoman Marina
    - Guest Speakers: Chairman Tony Johnson, Irene Martin, Todd Souvenir
- **Workshop 2: Restoring and Managing Salmon in Wahkiakum Streams**, February 25, 2026, 9:15 AM - 2:30 PM, Skamokawa Grange
    - 49 attendees
    - Site Visits: Nelson Creek Restoration, Dead Slough Restoration
    - Guest Speakers: Amelia Johnson, Bryce Glaser, Commissioner Dan Cothren, Darin Houpt, Ian Sinks
- **Workshop 3: Mitigating Flooding in Wahkiakum's Tidal Stream Reaches**, March 25, 2026, 9:15 AM - 2:30 PM, Rosburg Hall
    - 34 attendees
    - Site Visit: Grays River Streamflow Gage
    - Guest Speakers: Jackson Blalock, Jay Horita, Brooke Bennett, Andy Bookter, Donny Dyer
- **Workshop 4: Living Behind Dikes in Wahkiakum County**, May 6, 2026, 9:15 AM - 2:30 PM Norse Hall
    - 40 attendees
    - Site Visit: Puget Island Diking District Pumps
    - Guest Speakers: Austin Smith, Tony Aegerter, Jerry Bowden, Judy Johnson

This report consolidates content from all four workshops by organizing recurring components into shared sections. For more detailed notes or agendas from any individual workshop, please contact us via our website: https://beav.es/WCG.

2.1 Group Agreements

Carrie Shofner, the Meeting Facilitator, welcomed attendees, thanked them for their time, and for their families and coworkers making it possible to be there. Group agreements were based on similar used in The Nature Conservancy's Emerald Edge Gatherings. Carrie shared these group agreements consistently across all workshops on a flipchart:

- **Suspend Judgement**
    - Carrie offered that when she's in spaces where she feels overwhelmed, it can be easy to retreat into old patterns and rush to judgement. This can cause a narrow vision where we can't see all the possibilities. She asked participants to suspend judgement just for the next five hours, so that eyes and minds can be wide open to new possibilities.
- **See the Wisdom in Every Experience**
    - Carrie explained that each participant was invited because the planning team saw wisdom that they uniquely had to offer in our time together today. Carrie asked them to see the same wisdom in each other.
- **Presence**

    - Carrie shared that presence is bringing as much of yourself as you feel comfortable and taking breaks as needed. This means that if we need to make a call, email or text, or just take a breath, we can step out of the room to take a break to do that, but when we're in this room together, we are present together. She asked participants to press their comfort zone, and try to show up and be present as much as they can.
- **Co-creation**
    - Carrie shared that we are creating something new together. This could look like talking to people we haven't before, and when we're out walking at the site, walking with someone we haven't walked with before. This gives us a chance to learn from others.

Attendees were asked if they agreed with each of these after they were shared. Sometimes they were asked to give a thumbs up/down. Attendees were then asked: Is there anything else we need to be able to work together? No new group agreements were offered.

2.2 Opening Circle

The first half of workshops were set up so that all attendees were seated in a circle around the room, with space at the front of the circle for the projector, screen, flipcharts, and microphone. Each workshop had an introductory opening circle. This section was led by a member of the Planning Team, with the responsibility rotating among team members. Going around the circle, participants introduced themselves by stating their name, their role, and their one hope (in one sentence) for the workshop that day. After the first workshop, attendees were first asked to partner up with someone they had not met, introduce themselves, and interview each other. Getting back into the circle, attendees then introduced their partner to the group by name, role, and one hope (in one sentence). It should be noted that many individuals did not restrict their comments to one sentence. No effort was made to curtail anyone's comments, and no attention was drawn to the oversight.

Opening circle at workshop 3. *Photo by Jessica Vik.*

Attendees made these expressions of hope for the day:

- Meeting new people, making new connections
- Increasing collaboration and trust
- Connecting people with relevant resources that their organization/group offers or that they are aware of
- Learning more about Wahkiakum County's ecology, hydrology, history, culture, hazards, fish, economy; and learn concerns and priorities of residents; learn about the history and concerns of the Chinook Indian Nation
- Hearing new perspectives
- Building bridges or seeing reconciliation from people who have differing views
- Contributing their skills and understanding on the topics of discussion
- Building on the energy and momentum of previous workshops/series
- To be fully present and learn more about what motivated folks to participate
- See new projects, including successes and failures
- To continue the idea of long-term thinking and long-term work on the lands and water

At Workshop 4, instead of asking for their one hope for the day, we asked people to share one thing that has resonated with them from the prior workshops. We heard the following:

- The series has opened their eyes to how much community means
- Getting to know the community more
- A sense of loss of abundance, and lack of clarity as to whether society is willing to pay the costs to achieve abundance again
- Being able to get a deeper understanding of the county, the area, the people, challenges, and opportunities
- Exchanging knowledge and having opportunities for learning
- Appreciation of the successful projects and their positive impacts on salmon fisheries and natural habitats
- Connections with people
- Care that the community has for each other and this county
- The importance of relationships and of collaboration
- The idea that salmon are our neighbors
- The chance to meet people and share ideas
- Everything in the county revolves around water
- The value of people who are willing to show up and do the work, the importance of building local capacity
- The openness to communication from different points of view
- A desire to see action items and future activities realized

2.3 Sharing Workshop Goals

After the opening circle, **Carrie Shofner**, the Meeting Facilitator, presented the agenda for the day on a flip chart.

Sam Shogren, Chair of the Wahkiakum County Marine Resources Committee, the host of the Common Ground workshops, then introduced the group to the mission of the Wahkiakum County Marine Resources Committee:

> *To engage and educate the residents of Wahkiakum County in stewarding this place we call home. Our goals are to strengthen community and ecosystem resilience, build partnerships, and support marine livelihoods*.

And the genesis of Wahkiakum Common Ground:

- the 2021-24 Bay to Bay: Community-Based Hazards and Habitat Resilience Planning in the Columbia River Estuary, project and workshops hosted by Pacific Conservation District [5] and
- the 2025 Wahkiakum Common Ground series hosted by Wahkiakum County Marine Resources Committee,

And the goals of Wahkiakum Common Ground:

- to build relationships
- foster trust, and
- increase understanding of collaborative watershed restoration and find common ground to improve the resilience of Wahkiakum County.

2.4 Guest presentations

All speakers were asked to provide a personal biography in advance of the workshop. **Sandra Staples-Bortner**, Vice Chair of the Marine Resources Committee, used these biographies to introduce each speaker in turn.

2.4.1 History of the Chinook Indian Nation and Federal Recognition, Tony Johnson, Chairman, Chinook Indian Nation

The Chinook Indian Nation. The Chinook Indian Nation (CIN) is made up of the five westernmost Chinookan-speaking tribes in modern day western Washington, the Willapa, Lower Chinook, and Wahkiakum, and modern-day Oregon, the Clatsop and Cathlamet. Tribal Chairman Tony A. (nashcio) Johnson shared some of his own lineage during his talk, including his great grandmother, Elizabeth Pickernel, was born in Brookfield, in 1884 'when salmon berries were in bloom' - a way in which time is held in unison with seasons and the ecosystems. His family comes from Arrows and Pickernels, his father is Kuniak, and many of his family lines are Lower Chinook, Wahkiakum, Clatsop, with ties to Salish-speaking neighbors including the Upper Chehalis and Tillamook. It is important context to note that modern towns throughout Wahkiakum Territory (and Chinook Territory as a whole) are very often built on or near the sites of villages or presence from CIN tribes. It is not a coincidence that these are good places for settlement (e.g., access to resources, natural shelter, etc.); the tribes have spent millennia stewarding these places and have an intricate understanding of using place. Chinook people in these

[5] https://wacoastalnetwork.com/bay-to-bay-community-based-coastal-resilience-action/

places were pushed from these areas to more remote locations, further from access to traditional resources and into areas with increased risks.

In 2001 the Tribe's federal recognition was restored but just 18 months later was rescinded unjustly under the Bush Administration. While the Tribe operates as a sovereign nation and does not rely on the federal government to bestow sovereignty, they also utilize a not-for-profit wing to ensure that the Tribe can effectively continue and expand critical community work. CIN is active in a number of areas including, but not limited to:

- Land and Natural Resource Management and Stewardship
- Cultural Programming (language revitalization, traditional harvest and gathering, song, dance, ceremony, and more)
- Education and Community Awareness (including substantial scholarship programs and engagement opportunities)
- Community Wellness and Resource Training (food bank and distribution, wellness classes, etc.)

CIN is currently made up of roughly 3,400 enrolled tribal members.

The History of the CIN's fight for Federal Recognition. From the outset CIN has been, for all intents and purposes, treated as a Native Nation but without access to the resources that other Nations are provided. The U.S. does not bestow sovereignty on tribes, it can only acknowledge the existing sovereignty, which is what federal recognition would mean for the CIN. Currently, the U.S. government has inconsistently acknowledged CIN's sovereign status, and thus restoring recognition is a critical component for CIN to move forward alongside other Pacific Northwest tribes. At the mouth of the Columbia River, there is no federally recognized tribe as it stands, and as long as the Chinook Indian Nation is not properly seated as the recognized Tribe of the region, other tribes will keep pushing for rights to this explicitly Chinook land.

Chairman Johnson emphasized that he was providing a very basic overview, more information can be found at: https://chinooknation.org/political-history/. The points around the history of the fight for recognition he highlighted were:

- The five tribes came together through village amalgamation - there was high mortality from European diseases and villages were shrinking.
- In 1851, a set of treaties at Tansy Point was signed. Anson Dart, the then Superintendent of Indian Affairs was ordered to move the tribes off their land, but they refused to be separated from place and ancestors. Five tribes independently signed treaties, but they were not ratified by Congress at the time, purposely (1852).
- The U.S. wanted to make a different treaty. Asking what they wanted in exchange for it - the tribes wanted the Naselle area including Chetlo Harbor, Long Island. They went to treaty negotiations at Chehalis River (1855), where Governor Stevens insisted that the tribes move to the Olympic Peninsula. This meeting included the Governor making threats to the tribes such as showing them the boats his people came in on and saying he would "put them on the boats, take them to the ocean, and drown them; that he would take off his hat and fill it with gold for their land if they would just go to the Olympic Peninsula." While minutes were recorded for this meeting by the U.S. government, these notes called them 'belligerent Indians', the true experiences of the Chinook were not recorded. The Chinooks resisted, refusing to leave the land. Maintaining an unbroken connection to place that remains today.

- In the 1890s, the tribe hired their first attorneys, seeking damages for the land that was taken, and pursued legislation, which they lost in 1905.
- In 1912 and 1925 there was some acknowledgement by the government, specifically the wins they have had in the Supreme Court, this recognition is important.
- Before the Indian Gaming Regulatory Act, most tribes were operating the same. They were programmatically (by the federal government) poorer folks living off the limited resources of the place. Once the Gaming law was established, federally recognized tribes benefited a lot, whereas other tribes, like the Chinook, were left out and unable to access resources that were critical for community revitalization.
- In 1979 the Chinook pursued a process that was created for federal acknowledgement, which included a letter of intent to be petitioned for recognition. That was a 21-year process that ultimately ended in recognition, in 2001, at the tail end of the Clinton administration.
- The comment period for the recognition of the tribe lasted until the next (Bush) administration, and with that new administration, the new secretary for Indian Affairs, who lacked any real experience working in Indian Country, succumbed to political pressure to revoke that recognition (2002).
    - The process for recognition is ongoing. They are trying to move a bill through Congress that has strong delegation support. They also have a federal court case to allow for re-petitioning. They have appealed to the Supreme Court about recognition, asking to be put on the Bureau of Indian Affairs' list of recognized tribes. This appeal was denied until other avenues are exhausted.

Ways to support recognition. Chairman Johnson encouraged attendees to visit ChinookJustice.org, https://www.nativelandscitizenalliance.org/, and ChinookNation.org to sign up for more information, and to reach out to their delegation members to help move their bill in Congress both in OR and WA. The community can play an important role in increasing pressure for CIN restoration of recognition. Benefits of recognition include:

- **Substantially increased employment opportunities** with competitive salaries and benefits, and significant benefits to the local economy across the board (natural resources and other industries).
- **Funding for medical and mental health support** in the community, including the addition of badly needed facilities
- **More resources available to the tribe to enhance resilience** (e.g., funding to move critical infrastructure outside the tsunami zone) as well as provide help for other community members to bolster against increased coastal risk
- Federal law (the Native American Graves Protection and Repatriation Act (NAGPRA) governs **the return of remains and artifacts from museums and other institutions**; some institutions will not return these to the CIN without federal recognition - this is a major injustice.
- **Increased capacity of the tribe to partner on restoration and infrastructure projects**, and stronger support for fish habitats and hatcheries, as well as to innovate in the forestry sector, transportation, housing, etc.
- **Protection of fishing and hunting rights** and local resources that support the broader community who rely on these resources (i.e. create public hunting opportunities and protect and manage populations to support hunting and fishing).

Partnership on watershed restoration. Chairman Johnson shared about their traditional stories that talk about how the land was when it was just the animals living in the world, the transition from animals to human beings, then human experiences on the land. Those stories tell why the world is the way it is - which streams should have a certain run of fish, which fish runs should be in different streams. This kind of knowledge can inform the work on habitat we are all engaged in. However, everything the CIN has shared or given (including the land we were on) has been taken away, and not to their benefit. Once Chinook is properly seated as a recognized tribe, that is when they would feel comfortable sharing their stories, their traditional ecological knowledge. One initiative the Tribe works on is land acquisition. They are working to acquire 400 acres of spruce forest along Willapa River, just outside of Raymond. They recently closed on a 45-acre parcel of wetland and freshwater bog/swamp habitat on Loomis Lake. They continue to work on a variety of land acquisitions, not for enhancement or protection, but to acquire more land within their territories, for whatever purpose it may be (e.g., affordable housing). For example, they acquired land where their tea grows, which then allows unfettered access to that resource for the tribe.

The **most important takeaway** is that community driven support for recognition is not a tool only to provide resources and justice for the Tribe, but <u>it will drive massive increases in financial assets to the region and allow the Tribe to effectively lead in protecting and preserving ways of life of the modern community (e.g. fishing, forestry, conservation, tourism, etc.).</u>

2.4.2 Cultural, Ecological and Economic Significance of Restoring Wahkiakum Watersheds, Irene Martin, Author

Occupational communities face challenging conditions. Martin argued that restoring Wahkiakum watersheds is deeply tied to the survival of rural occupational communities involved in fishing, farming, and logging, which face high poverty, poor health outcomes and economic decline. In 2005 and 2014, Martin documented fishing community statistics finding that two-thirds of licensed Columbia gillnetters live in Wahkiakum, Clatsop, Pacific and Cowlitz counties, areas with elevated rates of poverty and health challenges. The average life expectancy of commercial fishermen is ten years younger than the average age of mortality.

Irene Martin asks attendees about local lingo. *Photo by Sanpisa Sritrairat*

The rural-urban divide and siloing contribute to problems. Many of these conditions exist due to a lack of recognition by wider society of the value of occupational communities (fishing, farming, logging, mining) which are the backbone of rural activity. Policies that favor local businesses and contribute to retaining fishers are needed - and the context of rural poverty is important to consider in designing such policies. The Urban-Rural divide is highly prevalent in Washington today. Small communities like the four counties of the Lower Columbia are against much larger state-urban communities that seem to be diametrically opposed - a struggle which is not uncommon. Within the county, there is isolation and a lack of communication which make watershed restoration work more challenging. Finding ways to have a shared language and understanding are needed, which was illustrated by the lack of knowledge of some attendees of specific local terms like ‘grouse ladder.’

Salmon are our neighbors, not ‘icons’. Martin challenged the framing of salmon and old growth trees as ‘icons’ (used for fundraising, commercial products), instead arguing that we should see them as our neighbors, and rather than focusing on the dead and dying (the adults), we should focus on what we can do for the living (the juveniles). Juvenile salmon do not often appear as ‘icons’ yet much of salmon mortality occurs in immature phases of the salmon life cycle. There is no ‘silver bullet’ solution to increase salmon populations, but to improve juvenile survival, more focus is needed on habitat. Watershed restoration is how habitat can be improved.

There are barriers to recovery. Some barriers to recovery include distrust in governmental and non-profit organizations. There is a sentiment that loggers and fishers have been demonized by these groups and agencies. Relationships between the urban cohort and landowners and local knowledge are needed for recovery. Landowners interested in supporting salmon habitat recovery must choose between financing recovery with their land or selling their property. Local poverty often includes people who are land rich but cash poor. Asking them to give up land is akin to asking them to give away their bank account, their children’s future. If land is needed for habitat, the owners should be paid. The carrot/stick approach has not been working because there have been “too many sticks and not enough carrots” (e.g., tax credits/deductions).

Returning to core values can help address challenges. The county has a history of overcoming challenges despite barriers, by drawing on core values. The values Martin argues are needed include:

- **Authenticity** - local communities can offer that long-term thinking, sense of ownership/stewardship of environment, they are not just bystanders
- **Resilience** - if a planned project is not working, there needs to be adaptive management, willingness to change when something doesn’t work
- **Showing up** - projects get done by people showing up, for example SR4 only came to be through the initial groundwork of volunteers hitching equipment to horses and creating them
- **Being Multilingual** - recognizing the language we speak may not be comprehensible to others. There is a speaker → listener → speaker, we need to be able to translate, to learn the languages important to what we are doing
- **Big-picture thinking** - thinking in terms of watersheds, and recognizing that we may not live to see results but that doesn’t mean we should not work because future generations depend on us
- **Meaningful advocacy that allows room for all stakeholders** - we need to reach out to those other people locked in solitudes. Variety makes advocacy stronger.

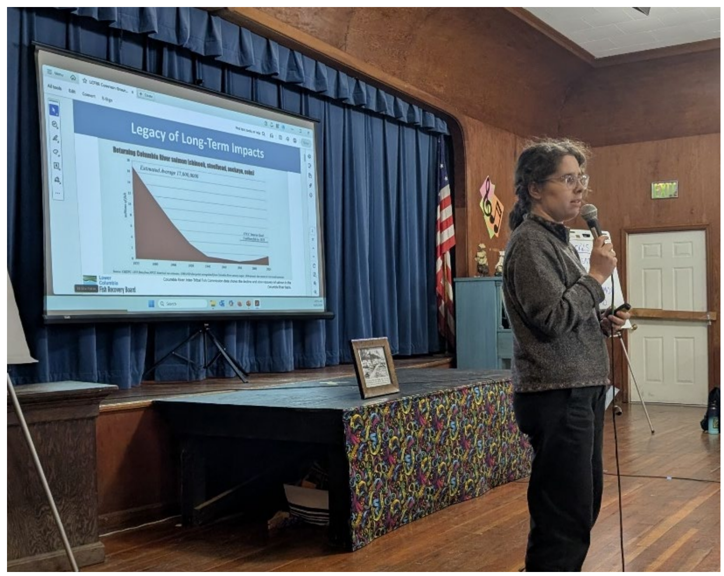
Martin concluded with a metaphor about trench warfare, and the way that conflict between enemies creates a poisoned no man’s land - the same thing can happen when we fight over watershed restoration. She asked attendees, “Can salmon swim through no man’s land?” and concluded by encouraging us to stop operating in solitudes:

“We need to recognize the value of cultural continuation and the problem-solving processes that will be needed to rebalance the demands and needs of our own watersheds and of our communities.”

2.4.3 Status of Salmon and Role of Habitat Restoration in Wahkiakum County - Amelia Johnson, Science Program Lead, Lower Columbia Fish Recovery Board

History of salmon in the county. In the mid-1800s, an estimated average of 17 million salmon (chinook, steelhead, sockeye, coho) returned to the Columbia River, but over time these populations drastically declined. In 1998, four Columbia River salmon and steelhead species were listed under the federal Endangered Species Act. In response, Washington state passed the Salmon Recovery Act, which created regional organizations (including LCFRB) that were tasked with working with community members to develop regional salmon recovery plans to be approved by NOAA. This process put regional entities–rather than federal agencies–in the lead role, which was a break from other endangered species recovery programs.

LCFRB. The Lower Columbia Fish Recovery Board (LCFRB) is one of the regional organizations that began work in 1998, on a recovery plan with the long-term goal of healthy and harvestable fish populations and productive fisheries. They work with a board made up of representatives from each of the five boards of county commissioners, a citizen from each of the five counties, from Cowlitz Indian Tribe, a local jurisdiction, and a hydroelectric company representative. They are also guided by a Technical Advisory Committee (TAC).



Amelia Johnson describes the status of salmon. *Photo by Sam Shogren*

LCFRB uses an “All-H” recovery approach, considering habitat, hatcheries, harvest, and hydropower together across the full life cycle of salmon and steelhead. There is no single solution to recovery and delisting, rather recovery requires multiple strategies. The relative influence of different “H” factors varies between species, but habitat restoration is a major component supporting recovery across species. They work with a recovery scenario with the goal of achieving minimum viability to delist the four species (Chinook, Chum, Steelhead, Coho) in the region from the Endangered Species Act by increasing the number, diversity and distribution of these species. They work with local partners to identify, implement, and assess (i.e., feasibility, design studies) projects to meet this goal.

LCFRB also maintains the LCFRB Salmon Resource Map[6] which reports habitat restoration investments. $34M has been invested in acquisition, planning efforts, and restoration in Coast Stratum, which includes all Wahkiakum County watersheds. Since 2001, WDFW and the Department of Ecology have collaborated to monitor fish and habitat each year in the Mill, Abernathy, and Germany Creek Intensively Monitored Watershed (IMW) area, which helps assess the effectiveness of habitat restoration. Key examples of the importance of IMW studies across the state were shared:

[6] https://lcfrb.org/salmon-resource-map

- **Coho Salmon Smolt:** Through life cycle monitoring, they identified that overwinter juvenile rearing is the main limiting life stage for coho salmon. Evaluation suggests that targeted and substantial habitat restoration (that ramped up in 2011 and continued through 2021) have increased Coho Salmon smolt production. A key takeaway from this specific work is the need to support watershed scale restoration, and to reconnect channels to support more habitat.
- **Skagit Estuary Intensively Monitored Watershed:** This work involved reconnecting lots of channels by removing levies and dikes. The project allowed fish populations to spread out more, compete less for resources and increase in productivity.

Recovery progress varies across the region and by species. Johnson shared some findings from the 2024 State of Salmon in Watersheds. This report is prepared every two years by the Salmon Recovery Office and WDFW. Species of fish included in the report that are present in Wahkiakum watersheds are: Lower Columbia River Chinook, Columbia River Chum, Lower Columbia Steelhead, and Lower Columbia River Coho. Of these species, Lower Columbia Coho are closest to meeting recovery goals, but recovery progress of species in the region varies. Focusing specifically on the Grays, Elochoman and Skamokawa and Mill, Abernathy and Germany watersheds:

- For Chum salmon, 1 out of 3 coastal populations are meeting goals, thanks in large part to grant-funded restoration and protection that have created or expanded viable populations;
- For Fall Chinook Salmon, <u>0 out of 3 populations are meeting goals</u>. There are very limited returns and high rates of hatchery-origin spawners in the coast watersheds. They are dealing with balancing habitat needs and fishery pressures, with the concern that ocean harvests disproportionately impacts these small populations. However, efforts for recovery for these populations, via habitat recovery, have the potential to reduce flood risk. The December floods highlighted the need to reconnect floodplains to reduce impacts of high-water events;
- For Coho Salmon, 1 out of 3 coast populations are meeting goals. A study monitoring Mill-Abernathy-Germany creeks found that rearing habitat was the key limitation for these populations, so the focus for recovery has been on habitat, improving fish passage and providing opportunities for access to habitat higher up in the watershed; and
- Winter steelhead status was not reported in the Salmon Report, but spawner abundance from 2019- 2025 suggests that the goals were met in Grays-Chinook in 2025; in Elochoman-Skamokawa in 2022, 2024, and 2025; and Mill-Abernathy-Germany “in zero years”. Because steelhead move higher up in watersheds than Chinook, habitat protection and restoration in headwaters/forest lands has been key.

Salmon recovery is a long-term proposition. These plans have been worked on for 25-26 years. The hope is that all the work they have done and are planning to do will lead to long-term recovery.

2.4.4 Fishery and Hatchery Management in Wahkiakum County, Bryce Glaser, Fish Program Manager, Southwest Region, Washington Department of Fish and Wildlife

Hatchery and Harvest management were the first of the four ‘H’s (Harvest, Habitat, Hatcheries, and Hydropower) to be addressed following the ESA listing, with significant actions being taken over the past few decades to address them.

Hatchery management. Benefits of hatcheries include that they provide fish for harvest, and can help build or sustain population abundance. A downside of hatcheries is that they can reduce natural population productivity, diversity, and abundance if not well-managed. Problems come from ecological interaction; competition for food and space; and genetic interaction (interbreeding, spawning, domestication). Hatchery management actions include:

- Production size changes
- Integrated ("wild") root stock programs - naturally produced fish are collected and integrated in the basin as a single population
- Segregated ("isolated") programs try to keep hatchery fish as separate from natural fish as possible.
- Fish removals - When hatchery-raised fish return to watersheds, they work to remove them through harvest (including commercial and sport harvest programs), weirs, beach seining, and hatchery returns
- Fish culture improvement - Upgrading infrastructure at older hatcheries

Harvest management. In Wahkiakum County, Harvest actions include:

- Mark-selective fisheries - they mark hatchery fish (clipping adipose fin to identify them as hatchery fish), only marked fish can be harvested
- Alternative commercial gear - tangle nets, beach seines, pound nets
- Improved assessment - Working on improving forecasts, how they predict the number of fish coming back, MSE – management strategy evaluation
- Improved monitoring - using creel modeling, using electronic catch record cards for sport anglers

Mitchell Act Program and Endangered Species Act compliance. Passed by Congress in 1938, the Mitchell Act supports salmon and steelhead production at state, federal, and tribal hatcheries throughout the mid- and lower Columbia River to help offset declines associated with the Columbia River hydropower system. Funding has not kept pace with inflation and rising costs. Because many of these species are listed under the Endangered Species Act (ESA), NOAA issues Biological Opinions (BiOps) that establish the terms and conditions tribes and states must follow in hatchery management. The first BiOp was issued in 2017, with an updated BiOp released in December 2024. These requirements include hatchery production limits, targets for the proportion of hatchery-origin spawners (pHOS), and take limits.

Hatchery actions in Wahkiakum County. Elochoman Salmon Hatchery was closed in 2009. This action was driven by a reduction in hatchery programs in that time, review by Congress, a Congressionally managed review group, and flood damage to the upper intake in 2006 that was too costly to repair given production reductions. Production was transferred to Beaver Creek and Grays River hatcheries. A high regional priority is to fully demolish and restore the hatchery, increasing access for recreation. This will cost $7-8M and is not yet funded. Grays River Hatchery was closed in January 2020. Intake was out of compliance, it was cost-prohibitive to bring it into compliance, there were concerns about flood risk due to continued sediment aggradation and it was not cost effective to restore or rebuild that facility. Production was transferred into Beaver Creek. Beaver Creek Hatchery reopened in the late 2000s, and there is a capital budget project to do full-scale renovation of the hatchery. The design is fully funded and nearly complete. Phase 1 construction is expected to be done by the next biennium. One thing that was learned from the closure of the Elochoman hatchery was the difficulty of getting funding for demolishing decommissioned hatcheries, so the capital budget request includes funding for work to demolish the Grays River Hatchery.

Fisheries management in Wahkiakum County. Fisheries management in Wahkiakum County and the Coast Stratum is primarily focused on controlling the proportion of hatchery-origin spawners (pHOS), which is a major challenge due to low wild population numbers and the influx of stray fall Chinook from Oregon hatchery programs. Management tools such as harvest regulations, weirs in the Grays, Elochoman, Abernathy, and Germany rivers, and beach seining are used both to manage hatchery influence and collect broodstock. The Grays River was designated a wild steelhead gene bank in 2016, ending local hatchery steelhead releases and shifting production to the Elochoman River. Similarly, the Deep River net pen program, which supported the Select Area Fishery Enhancement (SAFE) fishery, was discontinued following the 2024 BiOp, with spring Chinook production relocated to the Kalama River. Ongoing stock assessments rely on adult monitoring through stream surveys and weirs and juvenile monitoring through rotary screw traps, providing data critical for fisheries management and population tracking. Tributary fisheries are all currently mark-selective, directing harvest on hatchery fish. Elochoman River is the primary fishery, hatchery programs release fish in those basins. Other tributaries (Chinook, Skamokawa, Mill, Abernathy, and Germany) are open with various seasons, focused more on catch and release of wild stock. A big challenge is providing public access to these fisheries. Columbia River fisheries are jointly managed by WDFW Columbia River Division (CRD) https://wdfw.wa.gov/fishing/management/columbia-river, and Oregon (Columbia River Compact, https://wdfw.wa.gov/fishing/management/columbia-river/compact). Glaser concluded by sharing the outlook for Columbia River fisheries for the upcoming season.

2.4.5 Finding Common Ground in Restoration of Skamokawa's Dead Slough, Darin Houpt, District Manager, Wahkiakum Conservation District

History of Dead Slough. Dead Slough is the historic Skamokawa Creek Channel [7]. In the 1920s, the community was trying to get the lower end of Skamokawa Creek dredged but faced issues. They finally realized that no matter how deep they dug, when the tides came in, they would still have water issues. Instead, they moved the entire creek to a new location west of the existing floodplain. The historic channel is now known as Dead Slough.

Dead Slough Restoration. This project (completed about twenty years ago) was motivated by concerns about erosion of the dike and flooding of neighboring properties that were occurring. Wahkiakum Conservation District partnered with landowners, and the project was mainly funded through LCFRB Salmon Recovery funding. There were five components to the project: an outlet structure at the lower end with a tidegate, two small culverts in the interior at road crossings that were upgraded for flow to improve fish passage, an inlet structure with a tidegate at the upper end and repairing the eroding dike. The old tidegate at the lower end was five feet in diameter, which had been modified with plywood to try to keep it open longer. The restoration project installed a muted tidegate regulator, which uses a side-hinged tide gate controlled by a float tank (modulator) to allow a regulated flow of water into the system. Bonneville Power Administration (BPA) was part of their expert review group. Originally, BPA wanted to have a fully open connection at the lower end of the floodplain to benefit salmon. Through conversations and a visit to the site, BPA saw how neighboring landowners were impacted by flooding and agreed to accept a muted tidegate regulator to balance benefits to people and fish. The Conservation District received money for the project from Bonneville Power through the State

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7 https://www.estuarypartnership.org/sites/default/files/restoration_site/files/DeadSlough080505_restoration_concept_map.pdf

Conservation Commission. The interior culverts, which were around five-feet diameter and failing, were also replaced. The first crossing on the east property was upgraded to a bridge. The other crossing was upgraded. Dike repairs were funded through the Department of Ecology floodplains program. This project balances benefits to people and fish and has been working and operational over a long time period.

Site Visit - Dead Slough

Attendees walked from the grange along the dike to the outlet structure. Darin explained the workings of the tidegate and reviewed BPA's original resistance to the muted tidegate regulator and eventual recognition that the project required finding an outcome that benefitted both fish and people (i.e., finding common ground). Responsibility for operation and maintenance is an ongoing management concern. Attendees took photos of the muted tidal regulator (MTR), and were able to see it in action because of the timing of the site visit and tides (i.e., the float tank modulator changed the tide gate openings and flow of water while attendees were on site).

The muted tidegate regulator opens. Photo by Sanpisa Sritrairat

2.4.6 Wahkiakum County's Timber History and Importance of County Trust Lands, Dan Cothren, County Commissioner, Wahkiakum County

Timber and Wahkiakum County. The county relies on timber to survive; 25-30% of the county budget is tied to timberlands. County revenue largely depends on markets for forest products and forest management practices. Cothren works with Manulife Forest Management and other industrial forest land managers, for whom he works as security, making daily patrols of the lands. During his patrols he sees places where he felled timber as a young man (including giant trees), much of it has been harvested again, but he also sees places where the timber has been left to grow.

The Department of Natural Resources (DNR) manages timberlands in the county (and throughout the state), referred to as "trust lands." Some of these lands are "school trust lands," set aside at statehood to benefit schools. Additionally, in the 1930s, many cut-over timberlands were abandoned by their owners who were unable to pay property taxes during the Depression. These lands reverted to county ownership. Known as "County Trust Lands," the state manages these lands on behalf of the county. The state manages the lands and takes 25% of revenue, whereas 75% goes back to the county. Because they are trust lands, timber sales have to be approved by the Board of Natural Resources. Cothren must go to the board to testify on behalf of those sales. Others are there to testify against the sales.

Often, the perception at these meetings is that the board is made up of the environmentalist community, and that the agenda is dominated by the environmental community. Cothren emphasized that people making these decisions are not from rural communities, and that people from urban settings do not understand how things operate in rural communities like Wahkiakum County; rather, they see the lands as a place to recreate.

There is a good relationship and good communication between the DNR and the County. Cothren is able to use his lifelong timber knowledge to help identify wood to harvest to support the county budget. Timber is necessary for the county's survival, and when markets are low, as they are now, that makes it difficult for the county. There are often challenges and prolonged litigation around sales. There have been a lot of layoffs at DNR, and there is a lot of miscommunication, along with a perception that the environmental community does not understand how the lands are operated and managed.

Timber sales on Wahkiakum County trust lands are only around $1M annually now. In the 1990s, the timber market was much higher, and lots of money was put into county reserve funds. DNR manages approximately 12,050 acres of Wahkiakum County trust lands. Around 3,000 acres of these Wahkiakum County trust lands were locked up by the state (i.e., not able to be harvested) as habitat for a threatened bird–the marbled murrelet. To make up for this loss of working land, DNR and the affected counties went to the WA Legislature and got an "encumbered land" bill passed, which helped reimburse and compensate the county for the land being locked up. The executive director of Columbia Land Trust testified alongside Cothren, resulting in the county receiving funds annually to compensate for that land. When land is encumbered for conservation purposes, they are appraised and the county receives revenue based on that.

One of the current efforts of the proposed Upper Grays River Community Forest, of which Columbia Land Trust is a partner (along with Wahkiakum County and Pacific County), is to purchase timberland on Fossil Creek and elsewhere in the upper Grays River watershed. Congresswoman Marie Glusenkamp Perez has provided $500K in federal funding and Columbia Land Trust is pursuing additional grants for land acquisition. Thanks to Cothren's history with the land and his career, he is able to see the lands regularly and believes trees are being harvested too young, meaning there is nothing to hold sediment back and the "watershed there is broken."

Cothren emphasized that partnerships have been key in the work that has been done. His final words were, "Communication is key; that's the number one goal."

2.4.7 Lessons Learned from Adaptation Efforts Across Tidal Floodplains, Jackson Blalock, Marine & Estuarine Resilience Program, Pacific Conservation District

Floodplain functionality. Floodplains provide habitat for fish, wildlife, and other species; support natural resources, economic activity, and human development; and slow and store floodwaters, reducing flooding, erosion, contamination, and land subsidence, and increasing groundwater recharge. Aberdeen, Hoquiam, and South Bend illustrate how development within historic floodplains has increased flood risk over time. In Aberdeen and Hoquiam, tidal mudflats near the mouth of the Chehalis River were filled to support urban and industrial development. Likewise, South Bend was historically a tidal marsh and floodplain, but today contains neighborhoods, Highway 101, and other infrastructure that experience frequent flooding during king tides and heavy rainfall.

Causes of flooding. Flooding can result from several interacting processes, including:

- River discharge

- Heavy or persistent rainfall and local drainage limitations (e.g., runoff from impervious surfaces such as roads)
- Coastal flooding
- Compound flooding, where multiple flood drivers occur simultaneously

Flooding is becoming more severe as sea levels rise. Higher sea levels raise groundwater elevations, increasing impacts to infrastructure such as septic systems. Sea-level rise also alters erosion and sediment deposition patterns, causing materials to move and accumulate in new locations. Understanding these physical processes is essential for developing effective adaptation strategies, as each watershed responds differently and local context matters.

Monitoring is a critical part of understanding how these systems function. As one example, the University of Washington (UW), in collaboration with Pacific Conservation District (PCD), has installed numerous water-level monitoring stations throughout South Bend and Raymond. Because traditional stream gages can be expensive to install and maintain, UW and PCD developed lower-cost monitoring stations that allow for more extensive local monitoring and improve understanding of how tides, river flows, and precipitation interact during flood events.

Jackson Blalock highlights the importance of local capacity.
Photo by Jessica Vik

River levels and tidal floodplains. Under normal conditions, rivers remain within their primary channels while adjacent sloughs and depressions are only partially inundated. During flood events, these low-lying areas begin to fill, temporarily storing floodwaters and reducing downstream flood peaks. As water levels continue to rise, however, their storage capacity is exceeded, allowing water to spread across the broader floodplain. Monitoring conducted by UW and PCD in the Lower Willapa suggests that extreme water levels are often driven more by tides than by river discharge, with local tributaries and small drainage basins (creeks) also playing an important role. Approximately 14% of Wahkiakum County's population lives within the floodplain. As the county begins planning flood resilience projects, nearby efforts in Grays Harbor County (34% of the population lives within the floodplain) and Pacific County (18%) provide examples of how neighboring communities are adapting to similar challenges.

Adapting to flooding. Four broad approaches to addressing compound flooding were discussed, with the overarching theme that no single strategy is appropriate everywhere. Instead, successful adaptation often requires combining multiple approaches based on local conditions, community priorities, and environmental processes:

- Harden - Keep water away from developed areas using engineered infrastructure such as dikes, levees, and shoreline armoring. Examples include riprap installations (e.g., Chinook County Park in Baker Bay) and agricultural dikes.
    - These approaches are well understood and can provide long-term shoreline stability, but they are less adaptable to changing conditions. If overtopped or breached, failures can be significant, and these structures can redirect wave energy,

reduce natural sediment deposition (potentially contributing to subsidence), and disconnect aquatic habitats from their floodplains.

- Soften - Recognize that flooding is likely to occur and accommodate water in controlled ways, such as through floodplain restoration or elevating structures.
    - Examples included floodplain restoration at Dos Rios Ranch Preserve in Modesto, California, and dune grass planting at North Cove to reduce coastal erosion.
    - Floodplain restoration can be less expensive than large, engineered infrastructure while allowing floodplains to naturally store water and sediment. However, these projects often require changes in land use, larger restoration areas, and coordination among multiple landowners.
    - The North Cove dune grass project illustrated the importance of collaboration. Led by David Cottrell, then a commissioner for Pacific County Drainage District No. 1, the project brought together partners including WSDOT, the local Grange, the Shoalwater Bay Indian Tribe, and the Washington Department of Ecology. The project demonstrated that communication and partnership are often as critical to project success as the engineering or restoration approach itself.
- Move - Relocate people and infrastructure away from areas facing chronic flood risk through strategies such as managed retreat.
    - The Shoalwater Bay Indian Tribe's relocation to higher ground was highlighted as an example of a successful long-term adaptation strategy. By moving the community out of the floodplain, the project greatly reduced flood risk while creating opportunities for new housing, infrastructure, and community development. However, this approach required substantial financial investment, long-term planning, and strong community support to achieve.
- Combination - Combine multiple adaptation strategies to address flood risk based on local conditions and community priorities.
    - The Chehalis River watershed and Lower Willapa resilience efforts were presented as examples of this approach. Both projects began by identifying community priorities through public engagement, then evaluating a range of adaptation options and openly discussing the associated tradeoffs before selecting preferred strategies.

Lessons learned. More information on projects can be found at WACoastalnetwork.com (Washington Coastal Hazards Risk Reduction Project Mapper). Blalock highlighted several key considerations for addressing compound flooding:

- Work with natural environmental processes and recognize the "landscape memory" of historic floodplains. Hard infrastructure has an important role but is not appropriate everywhere.
- Break large watersheds into smaller planning areas to prioritize actions and implementation.
- Develop multiple projects at different scales that reinforce one another.
- Engage stakeholders and technical experts together when defining project scope and priorities.
- Identify a range of adaptation options and openly discuss tradeoffs.
- Recognize that flood-prone areas will continue to get wet; adaptation focuses on managing where, how often, and how long flooding occurs, rather than eliminating flooding entirely. Do not let perfect be the enemy of the good.
- Integrate ecological priorities (fish, birds, and habitats), infrastructure needs, and economic benefits to create stronger funding opportunities.
- Use small pilot projects to test ideas, demonstrate success, and build community support.

- Document project outcomes and improve future decision-making through continued monitoring.
- Build long-term local capacity by creating permanent or part-time staff positions supported through project funding.

Question & Answer

- Participants discussed next steps for flood resilience efforts in the Grays River watershed. Although PCD has submitted a grant proposal to the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers, shifting federal priorities have delayed funding. Progress depends not only on implementing individual projects, but also on building community support, improving communication, and developing a shared long-term vision for the watershed.
- The discussion emphasized the value of addressing interconnected watershed issues collaboratively rather than in isolation. Participants highlighted the importance of identifying community goals, establishing metrics for success, improving access to data and technical expertise, and evaluating a range of adaptation strategies rather than relying on a single solution. They also noted the need to strengthen local capacity through grant assistance, partnerships, and investment in community-based staff.
- Blalock concluded by emphasizing that local leadership is essential. While technical experts and partner organizations can provide support, training, and funding assistance, lasting progress depends on community members who understand local conditions, build relationships, and sustain collaboration over time. He also emphasized that pilot projects provide valuable opportunities for communities to learn, build trust, demonstrate success, and create momentum for future resilience efforts.

2.4.8 East Fork Deep River Connectivity Phase 1, Jay Horita, Habitat Restoration Project Manager, Columbia River Estuary Study Taskforce (CREST)

Current conditions in Deep River. Horita described conditions in the East Fork Deep River approximately two miles upstream from the confluence with the mainstem Deep River. The area historically functioned as a floodplain but is now primarily used for cattle ranching and hay production.

Jay Horita introduces the project. *Photo by Jessica Vik*

The primary project area is located where the East Fork joins the mainstem. Existing culverts and tide gates have deteriorated, with many culverts partially or completely collapsed. These failures have reduced drainage capacity, blocked fish passage, and contributed to chronic flooding. Water frequently ponds near roads and structures, and the floodplain becomes inundated even during relatively minor flood events.

The northern project boundary is near Wirkkala Road, where sheet flow commonly overtops the roadway. Flooding has become severe enough that some landowners have resorted to using a dinghy to reach vehicles parked outside flooded areas.

Solutions. The project consists of multiple phases designed to improve flood resilience while restoring ecological function. Partners in the project include CREST, the landowners in East Fork valley, and Wahkiakum County. Major components include:

- Removing existing 4-foot-diameter culverts and outdated tide gates.
- Installing new box culverts and a muted tidal regulator (MTR).
- Constructing floodplain benches to improve habitat.
- Relieving channel constrictions.
- Excavating additional flood storage areas to reduce flooding around roads and structures.
- Reusing excavated material through thin-layer placement on adjacent agricultural fields to improve soil productivity, fill low spots, and reduce the risk of fish becoming stranded, while avoiding the cost of hauling excavated material off site.

The proposed muted tidal regulator will include a 12 × 21-foot inlet opening, an approximately 10 × 10-foot upstream outlet opening, reinforced wingwalls, riprap protecting the road embankment, side-hinged gates, and an upstream counterweight system.

Muted tide gate regulator design. Horita explained that traditional tide gates are default closed to upstream tidal flow. They remain closed until sufficient interior water pressure forces them open, limiting fish passage and reducing tidal exchange for extended periods. The proposed muted tidal regulator functions differently. It is default open, allowing fish to move upstream during incoming tides until a user-defined interior water surface elevation is reached. Once that threshold is exceeded, the gate automatically closes to prevent excessive flooding of adjacent lands. Although unrestricted fish passage remains the preferred ecological outcome, Horita emphasized that the muted tidal regulator represents a practical compromise that balances fish passage, flood protection, agricultural land use, and infrastructure protection.

Challenges. Horita discussed several challenges encountered throughout the project.

A primary challenge has been balancing competing priorities among stakeholders with different objectives. He emphasized the importance of "drawing the fine line of what everyone can accept," requiring each stakeholder to compromise in pursuit of an overall solution.

Examples of competing priorities included:

- Landowners: Reducing flooding that affects homes, roads, and services (including school bus access).
- Wahkiakum County: Long-term operation, maintenance responsibilities, and system capacity.
- Regulatory agencies: Fish passage requirements and permitting compliance (NEPA and ESA).
- Funding agencies: Maintaining reasonable project costs while satisfying detailed grant requirements.

The project's long timeline has presented additional challenges. Although the current phase has been under development for more than seven years, many landowners have dealt with flooding issues for decades. Changes in land ownership have required rebuilding relationships with new property owners throughout project development.

Funding has also been a significant challenge. Construction bids exceeded available budgets, requiring additional grant applications and phased implementation. Horita noted that federal grant requirements can be highly specific—for example, restricting the use of certain construction materials based on manufacturing location. Navigating permitting requirements has also proven complex, as detailed permit conditions are sometimes difficult to interpret.

Question & Answer

- Horita explained that successful collaboration with landowners has required extensive relationship-building and consistent communication over many years. He credited former CREST project manager Tracy Hruska with working closely with landowners to develop a solution they could support, ultimately helping secure buy-in from regulatory agencies, funders, and community members.
- Attendees asked about long-term maintenance, project costs, and operational responsibilities. Horita stated that construction is estimated to cost approximately $4.2 million. Because the muted tidal regulator is a relatively new approach, funding agencies required a detailed operations and maintenance plan, which underwent several revisions during project development.
- Following construction, CREST and Pacific County will jointly oversee operation and maintenance of the system in consultation with participating landowners. The project also includes a post-construction calibration period, during which water level thresholds can be adjusted to improve fish passage while avoiding unacceptable impacts to adjacent properties.
- CREST also discussed the challenges associated with securing restoration funding, including reimbursement-based grants, matching fund requirements, and limited local administrative capacity. The organization, which celebrates its 50th anniversary in 2025, provides grant writing and project administration support for many restoration efforts and is funded largely through a contract with the Bonneville Power Administration.
- In response to questions about adaptive management, Horita explained that any future operational changes to the muted tidal regulator would require review and approval by the project's major partners through an established decision-making process.

2.4.9 Voluntary Stewardship Program, Brooke Bennett, Voluntary Stewardship Program Coordinator, Wahkiakum Conservation District

History of the Voluntary Stewardship Program. Rising urban growth and land use issues prompted legislative action, leading to passage of the Washington Growth Management Act (GMA) in 1990. The GMA recognized that unplanned growth threatened environmental quality, economic development, and quality of life, and emphasized coordinated, locally driven land-use planning (RCW 36.70A).

The GMA raised important questions about balancing growth with conservation: How do we reduce sprawl, protect open space and habitat, support resource-based industries, and encourage public participation? Counties addressed these questions through comprehensive planning. As they developed plans and ordinances in the 2000s, conflicts sometimes arose between agricultural activities and critical area protections, resulting in litigation.

The Voluntary Stewardship Program (VSP) was established in 2011 as an alternative approach to resolving these conflicts while protecting critical areas and maintaining viable agriculture. Today, 28 of Washington's 39 counties participate in VSP. Counties that do not participate may have limited agricultural activity or use alternative approaches, such as Snohomish County's Farm Fish Flood Initiative.

Brooke Bennett presents on the VSP. *Photo by Sam Shogren*

In 2025, Wahkiakum County Commissioners voted to opt into VSP. The Wahkiakum Conservation District will administer the program locally and report to the Washington State Conservation Commission (WSCC), which provides program funding.

VSP approach. VSP is an approach for addressing local problems with flooding that take into account farms. VSP projects address issues where critical areas intersect with agricultural activities. Critical areas are defined as fish and wildlife habitats, wetlands, frequently flooded areas, critical aquifer recharge areas, and landslide-prone slopes. Agricultural activities are more broadly defined: raising livestock, storing ag equipment on lands, growing food, and more. VSP targets ag activities, and you can participate regardless of how your land is zoned or your property tax status, allowing greater participation by county residents.

VSP Work Plan. WSCC wants to understand what critical areas, issues, and agriculture shape the identity of Wahkiakum County, and importantly, where agricultural activities overlap with critical areas. Long-term planning, thinking fifty and a hundred years ahead, is part of this work. The background history and goal-setting work will be summarized and shared back to WSCC in a **work plan**. For Wahkiakum, this may look like describing the prevalence of salmon-bearing streams, erosion issues, loss of hayfields, and high levels of sedimentation, and summarizing the existing projects being done to address these issues. The work plan must be created with public input. In addition to public outreach at Common Ground, two VSP meetings will be held in April 2026. These public, informational meetings seek to identify people to participate in a focused 'watershed work group.' This group should be a representative sample of landowners, agency folks, tribal members, and environmental groups. The work plan will be submitted to the Washington State Conservation Commission by 2028.

Benefits of VSP. By participating in VSP, Wahkiakum Conservation District will receive around $300k every 2 years from WSCC to support on-the-ground projects. This is important for WCD because it is money they do not need to compete for. This money will boost the Wahkiakum Conservation District and Wahkiakum County by supporting the kinds of projects they are already doing. Compared with other more strict programs (e.g., CREP), where landowners are often required to follow strict requirements (e.g., certain buffers are required) or sign 10-15 year contracts, the VSP program is flexible. For landowners coming to WCD through VSP, the WCD will develop a project design, and something called an individual stewardship plan, which is very flexible, without strict requirements. VSP reflects the belief that at a watershed scale, if people are given the option to restore their property voluntarily, through a customizable, flexible program, the results will be better than a top-down approach.

2.4.10 Grays River Streamflow Gage, Andy Bookter, Hydrologist, Washington Department of Ecology

Key terms:

- Stage - confirmed water elevation above a datum
- Gage height - stage
- Gage index - a physical reference point used to measure stage
- Datum - a reference elevation used to calculate stage
- Streamflow or discharge - measured volume of water
- Stream gage - structure installed beside a river that contains equipment to measure and record water level
- Note that hydrologists/hydrographers use 'gage' rather than 'gage'

Original gage station. The original gage station at Grays River was installed by the WA Department of Ecology in 2005, just downstream of the covered bridge. It measured both stream stage and flow. In 2014, due to funding cuts at Wahkiakum County, the flow function was discontinued. Since then the station has only measured river stage. The infrastructure of the original gage, the station house, is still there. The Department of Ecology maintains the system, with their costs reimbursed by the county. The main maintenance required is removing weeds around the station house. Gage indices and a passive crest gage help Bookter to check the accuracy of the instrument. The station has a bubbler system, which pushes a bubble of air every second through the orifice line (some tubing) that goes through hardened pipe fixed in place under water. A challenge at Grays River is the immense amount of sediment moving downstream each year. In the 2019 photo (below), you can see where Bookter had to dig down through sediment on the bank to use the laser level; it was covered by 24 inches of sediment. The staff gage on the bank also was no longer useful. The bottom of the river was at a much higher elevation than when the staff was installed.

Updated station. In 2021, the Department of Ecology installed new electronics and moved all the instrumentation from the bank to the covered bridge to avoid the problem of heavy sedimentation on the bank. A radar gage, which operates by sending a radar signal to the bottom of the river, was installed to measure the stage/height of the river above the bottom–a more accurate measurement of stage. In 2023, due to flooding and a desire by the community to use the gage for flood forecasting, Bookter increased the frequency of data transmission to hourly, "near real time." On October 1, 2023, the reference datum for stream stage was changed to station elevation (NAVD88).

Data accuracy and access. Checking for accuracy is important. They use the laser level and staff gage to confirm the radar readings. They use the laser level with a known elevation laser pad on the bank, and bounce the laser off a stadia rod which gives them a stage in feet. The staff gage is simpler, just reading the water level off of the staff plate. The crest stage gage is used to read high flow events when they exceed the banks. It includes caps at the top and bottom, with a cork inside. When water rises and drops, it leaves a cork line. Measuring the cork line and adding elevation gives a measure of high flow stage. Bookter uses the data to check the accuracy of records, and make corrections where needed.

The stage records are available to the public; shown on a graph, on the y-axis, they show stage level, on the x-axis is the date. To make corrections, they compare the stage records to gage index checks. After a visit they can download the logger, check it, and correct records as needed. Data is uploaded using the NOAA satellite system, powered by solar panels and batteries. The data goes through servers to the Department of Ecology, where they do quality checks and develop rating curves. Data from the gage is available online to the public.

- Department of Ecology App: https://apps.ecology.wa.gov/ContinuousFlowAndWQ/StationDetails?sta=25B060
    - Includes corrections and notes that Bookter provides for data users
- There also is the NOAA flood forecast site, but that data is not corrected like it is with the Department of Ecology app.

Flood forecast stages now include an additional level of 'moderate.' (Previously - action, minor, major; Current - action, minor, moderate, major)

Site visit - Grays River Covered Bridge and Streamflow Gage

Attendees visited the covered bridge to view the gages. Donny Dyer, Director, Grays River Flood Control District, pointed out the gages/station that Andy had covered in his Zoom presentation. It was raining quite a bit, but attendees walked the length of the bridge and had a look at the gages from a distance.

Attendees cross the covered bridge to see the gage.
Photo by Sam Shogren

2.4.11 Wahkiakum County Emergency Management Program, Austin Smith, Emergency Management Coordinator, Department of Emergency Management, Wahkiakum County Sheriff's Office

Emergency Management Functions and Responsibilities. The sheriff's office is the organization established by county code and town resolution to oversee emergency management functions here in Wahkiakum County. Sheriff Mason, who by code, oversees Emergency Management for the County, has delegated most of the responsibility for day to day responsibility to Austin Smith as the department's emergency management coordinator. Smith plans with other agencies for hazard preparedness and response, including coordinating their Emergency Operations Center during hazard events. He coordinates search and rescue teams, serves as the homeland security advisor for the Board of County Commissioners, and works with other counties in Region 4 for anything related to emergency management. There are five core mission areas in emergency management related to preparedness, mitigation, response, and recovery (the disaster cycle). There are 32 core capabilities that fall into these core mission areas. Wahkiakum County's Emergency Management Office does preparedness, mitigation, and response for any incident that would affect the county. This work involves a lot of public outreach/education. For example, educating our neighbors to have two weeks of emergency supplies ready to sustain themselves in the event of a severe weather event or coastal hazard. The estimate is that it will take at least two weeks, if not more, for help to arrive.

Disasters in Wahkiakum County. In the past 30 years, there have been 21 federally declared disasters in the county. Flooding occurs annually on the ”West End.” The most recent presidentially declared disaster in December of 2025 included flooding and landslides (https://governor.wa.gov/sites/default/files/2025-12/SUMMARY%203629-EM.pdf). Impacts of this flood included roads being washed out, and power outages lasting 8 to16 hours. With power outages, there was a concern that pump stations on Puget Island were not powered and water would overtop the dikes. Another major concern was the senior population in the community that might rely on medical equipment that required power. Smith tried to coordinate how to get power and oxygen to folks in need with medical complications. Smith also got in contact with the diking district and sought information from Bonneville Power Administration (BPA) about how long the power would be out, and how long before overtopping happened. Another part of the response was to begin thinking about how we would go about evacuating the 1200 to 1400 people living on Puget Island if overtopping were to occur. After this disaster, Emergency Manager Smith started to consider options for the future, whether generators would be needed and how to get electricians to operate them.

Question & Answer

The discussion focused on evacuation planning, emergency response, and community preparedness.

- Dan Cothren noted that newcomers to Wahkiakum County may not realize the extent of local disaster risks or that county resources may be limited during major emergencies.
- The Sheriff's Office can request helicopter assistance directly from the Coast Guard in Astoria and may also seek support from resources such as the National Guard. Participants discussed evacuation options if both west-end exits are blocked, including re-establishing agreements with private timber companies to use logging roads for emergency access. Related transportation resiliency work is also underway to identify standards for safely using these routes during emergencies.
- Attendees also asked about preparedness for livestock and agricultural operations. Health and Human Services has been working to improve resilience in the agricultural community through outreach and educational events focused on flooding and livestock impacts.
- In response to questions about power outages affecting pump operations during the December 2025 storm, speakers noted that backup generators would provide the best long-term mitigation but are costly. Representatives from the Puget Island Diking District (Wahkiakum County Diking District No. 1) described their practice of lowering water levels ahead of storms to increase storage capacity and reduce flood risk, while acknowledging that some residents living outside the dikes remain particularly vulnerable.

2.4.12 Panel: Living Behind Dikes in Wahkiakum County, Judy Johnson, Director, Grays River Flood Control District; Tony Aegerter, Commissioner, Wahkiakum County Diking District No. 1; Jerry Bowden, Commissioner, Wahkiakum County Diking District No. 5

Sandra Staples-Bortner provided some context drawing on Irene Martin's book (B*each of Heaven: A History of Wahkiakum County*, 1997), prior to introducing the panelists. The first Extension agent, George Nelson, arrived in Wahkiakum County in 1912, when the population was 5,000 people (more than the estimated 4,800 that are here today). At that time, there were 140 farms with an average size of 26 acres. Extension Agent Nelson led the diking effort, gathering the signatures needed to establish the diking districts. Dikes were established during the first three decades of the 1900s.

Panelists were initially asked to respond to three questions from the moderator.

What is the primary purpose of your district?

Sandra Staples-Bortner moderates the panel, from left to right Judy Johnson, Jerry Bowden, and Tony Aegerter. *Photo by Sanpisa Sritrairat*

Johnson explained that, according to Washington State RCWs, the GRFCD's primary purpose is flood control and diking. The district was originally created to maintain flood protection infrastructure for the protection of property, public health, conservation, and the development of natural resources. The district is also authorized to provide management for the Grays River and all of its tributaries in order to protect the region from flooding and water-related impacts. The district has existed for 84 years and has had many dedicated directors over time. Directors serve six-year terms. For ~60 years, the district's work focused primarily on the upper regions of the watershed, from Gorley Springs to the middle reaches of the Grays River. The watershed itself extends from Hull Creek down to the Columbia River. In 2003, the district annexed additional territory to include the entire watershed down to the mouth of the river. As a result, projects that had historically been concentrated in the upper watershed shifted toward the middle and lower portions near the mouth of the river.

Bowden shared that Diking District 5 (lower Skamokawa Creek)'s purpose is to maintain the dikes. The board is relatively new, with only one of the three members having been on the board long-term. The district was defunct for a period of time due to limited interest and lack of funding and now dikes are in disrepair. About a year ago (2025) they got organized and have been working towards solutions.

Aegerter shared that the Puget Island Diking District (No. 1) operates formally as a drainage district with two systems - the big island and the little island. Puget Island was named after Peter Puget, settled in 1884, and formally organized in 1914. The island's dike system was completed in 1917 to help control seasonal flooding and freshets from the Columbia River. Before the dikes were built, many homes were constructed on pilings along the island's edges, and the river served as the primary transportation route since there were no roads. When the dikes were installed, many of those homes remained outside the dike system, making the area somewhat unique. The island includes about 3500 acres. After the dikes were completed, farming expanded rapidly, followed by the growth of the dairy industry in later decades. By 1939, a bridge connected the island to the mainland. Around that time, the United States Army Corps of Engineers took over management of the flood control system and upgraded portions of the infrastructure. Over time, the system evolved from relying mainly on tide gates to using pump stations for water management during winter conditions. Many infrastructure upgrades were tied to development of the 40-foot deep shipping channel, though much of the existing infrastructure is now at least 50 years old.

What is unique to your district?

Johnson shared that the most unique thing about the Grays River Flood Control District is that it is composed of 38 tide gates and dikes, and they are all privately owned. They work with 340 parcels and landowners who individually control those tide gates and dikes, and they are all very different in size and flow type. The West End is primarily agricultural/livestock based. Dikes were built to support this rural community and protect pastureland. Johnson showed us a graph of the flood window–times during the year with historic flood potential. Because of this winter 'flood window,' summertime is when they are able to maintain the dikes and tide gates of the drainage district. They are also responsible for updating the county's basemap for the 340 parcels, which had not been done since 2013. Through a lot of effort, they brought the basemap and parcel profiles up to date, which is important because it is tied to assessments. Assessments are based on acreage and location. Properties on the river are assessed a certain amount whereas someone living off the river/uphill pays less (3$ on river, 1$ not on river). Funds from these assessments are used to repair broken tide gates during emergencies. Over the past years, they have funded 50% of repairs during emergencies. They have access to boats and often travel the river to inspect/evaluate dikes and tide gates.

Bowden shared that District 5 is unique because it is small. They have ~8 property owners who pay assessment fees to the diking districts. The district encompasses more properties, but other properties included aren't assessed any fees. Annual revenue of the district is $2,400, which barely pays insurance. The diking district is quite old, with facilities in disrepair. They are seeking external funds to repair a growing list of issues. Last summer they focused on research and discovery of these issues.

Aegerter shared that Puget Island is unique because they are not connected to the mainland in any way, and there is only one reliable way off the island, the bridge. There are also some houses that exist outside the dike which aren't part of their district and can't be taxed. The diking district does not offer them protection because they are outside the dike.

What challenges (particularly related to natural hazards, e.g., king tides, tsunami, river flooding, water from uphill) is your district dealing with? OR What successes from your district would you like to highlight? What partnerships or collaborations contributed to these successes?

Flooding is a challenge for the GRFCD. The months highlighted on the chart provided by Johnson show periods when flooding is *expected,* not just possible. They typically experience at least one flood each year, and the agricultural community is accustomed to managing those conditions. In the upper watershed, flooding is primarily caused by rainfall, log debris, and snowmelt. One of their major challenges upriver has also been catastrophic land collapse, which at one point wiped out an entire area, including a house and the surrounding property. In the lower part of the river, the biggest challenge comes from King Tides occurring at the same time as major rainfall events. If strong winds occur simultaneously, the King Tides back up the water, causing the river to crest. The chart shows the size and severity of those flood crests.

Bowden highlighted that financial issues and dealing with an aging diking system are the district's major challenges. Their success so far has been identification/discovery of the issues they need to address.

On Puget Island, there are also issues with aging infrastructure, much of which is 50+ years old. People moving to the island may lack awareness they are behind the dike. Dealing with Army Corps of Engineers and changes in their policies, which impacts their maintenance, can be difficult. The district is also struggling with training the workforce and finding new people to take on roles of people who are close to retirement.

Panelists were then asked to respond to these questions from the audience.

How are fees assessed and rates set? Who has the authority to change those?

The Grays River Flood Control District assessment is based on acreage and whether the parcel is on the water or not. Property less than 25 acres only pay $25 per year. The rates have been continuing through the existence of the board, but assessors can be brought in to reassess the parcels to determine whether rates should change.

Each diking district is considered a junior taxing district. In Diking District 1, rates are determined annually through their budgeting process. They set a budget of maintenance needs for the year, and then assess individual landowners accordingly. They base fees on value per 1000.

In District 5, they use a similar type of assessment as District 1. Even if they doubled rates, they still would not have sufficient funding (revenue ~$5000/year). Many properties in their district are assessed at a minimum and reap the benefits while paying only $20-25 per year.

For all diking districts, there are no limitations on how much rates can change year to year.

At meetings of the diking districts, how does climate change get discussed, specifically concerns about more precipitation and sea-level rise?

At District 1 and District 5 meetings, they never discuss climate change. Johnson shared that they plan for a 100-year flood, with recognition that floods have fluctuated a lot over time.

What partnerships or collaborations contributed to your activities/successes?

GRFCD collaborates with the 340 parcel owners and has a network of farmers who help other farmers with repairs of dikes, tide gates, and ditches. Many of the former flood control district commissioners still reside in the district and have generational knowledge. The district works with the Department of Ecology on stream gages to assess flood conditions. They also collaborate with the citizen's advisory committee, Sea Grant, and the Department of Fish and Wildlife.

Bowden (District 5) has been collaborating with the Department of Fish and Wildlife to develop fish habitat projects while addressing flooding concerns. One of those projects was planned to be discussed that night at a Diking District Meeting which all attendees were invited to attend.

Aegerter (District 1) emphasized the importance of partnerships and shared community investment. He described how residents, local districts, longtime island families, and newer community members are all working together toward shared goals. Volunteers contribute significant time and skills and local contractors are actively involved. Although the district is one of the larger diking districts, Aegerter noted that financially they are still a relatively small client for companies like JH Kelly, but those companies have continued to support local communities. He also highlighted partnerships with organizations including Army Corps of Engineers, Lower Columbia Fish Recovery Board, Department of Fish and Wildlife, and everyday volunteers.

2.5 Site Visits

Site visits not associated with a presentation are described here.

2.5.1 Elochoman Marina - Todd Souvenir, Manager, Wahkiakum County Port District No. 1 (Elochoman Marina)

Todd Souvenir points out the dock replacement. *Photo by Andrea Mah*

Port 1 has some limitations in terms of its capacity to contribute to the economic base of Wahkiakum County. The Port is not located on the main stem of the Columbia River making it not a deep-water port. It also is far from I-5, and lacks rail access. A majority of the Port's revenue (50-60%) is related to spring and fall fishing. The Port also has a small tax base. Port projects and amenities are focused on providing customer service and improving the tourist experience to develop repeat customer visits. Recent capital improvements at the port include:

- Improvements for dike campsites providing water and power access

- Conversion of select campsites to RV sites
    - Upgrading amenities allows them to generate much more money, increasing the rate from $20 per site to $45 per night.
- Installation of a new fish cleaning station, with the support of a Wahkiakum MRC grant in 2024.
    - The Port is currently working with the school district to develop signage containing QR codes to social media to allow people to share their catches and indirectly promote the port.
- Replacement of the “D” Dock in 2021, at a cost of $300,000, including installation of 18 finger docks and replacement of 200 feet of dock. Staff completed most of the work which helped reduce project costs.
- Acquisition of a house on adjacent property which will be remodeled and used as a rental cabin.
- Improvements to the appearance of existing cabins (built in 1996).
- Remodeling of Kells’ Snack Shack (building owned by the port), including a commercial kitchen.
- Creation of a food cart area, with plans to secure more vendors.
    - The Cathlamet Haircut Hut provides haircuts and shaves
- The commercial fisheries memorial shows the history of the area and includes a fish carving by a local artist (who also created the firepits and planters at Salt and Tomato’s outdoor patio.
- Construction of a viewing deck through an MRC grant in 2019–2020, which has been used for several weddings since installation.
    - The building of the deck was one of Souvenir’s first experiences working with government permitting. He shared that they had to change it from a ‘viewing deck’ to a ‘pier’ so that they could build it out further per county/town code.
    - Souvenir learned during the site visit from WDFW personnel that he should have gotten a shoreline permit for the project and plans to address this oversight.
    - A challenge during construction was the increased cost of materials, but the company who built it was instead offered the opportunity to have a small plaque with their name affixed to the deck, which led to them being hired for other local work.
- Installation of interpretive signage by the Chinook Indian Nation which provides more history on the area. There is additional Chinook signage throughout the town at Queen Sally’s Well (adjacent to the Pioneer Community Center [former church]) and the Pioneer Cemetery (behind the elementary/middle schools).
- The Salt and Tomato Restaurant & River Mile 38 Brewery and Tasting Room, owned by Javier Sanchez and Rex Czuba, are important additions to the port which give people a reason to stop in the area (e.g., boaters, yacht clubs, people travelling by RV).
- The port has a barbeque shelter which is open to the public, and which can be reserved ahead of time. The shelter is used several times a year by the Cathlamet Yacht Club to hold events and to host visiting yacht clubs traveling to Cathlamet on their boats.
- Washrooms are available 24/7, including public showers.
- A street market is held each Friday in the summer (not a farmer’s market, because getting fresh produce sellers consistently is difficult).

Port Manager Todd Souvenir also discussed important local events and resources that draw customers to the marina in addition to fishing, such as Bald Eagle Days, Regattas, Rallies, and the Wooden Boat Show. Future projects that will benefit the port include development of an adjacent property owned by the Town of Cathlamet into a waterside park with support from an RCO grant.

2.5.2 Finding Common Ground at Nelson Creek - Ian Sinks, Stewardship Director, Columbia Land Trust

Ian Sinks presents at the Nelson Creek site. *Photo by Sam Shogren*

This site, which we also visited as part of last year's series, represents a successful collaboration between Wahkiakum County and the Columbia Land Trust. While Sinks led the site visit, Commissioner Dan Cothren also shared his reflections on the work.

The project was motivated by issues with flooding of the road and neighboring property and salmon moving upstream to spawn becoming stranded. The project covers 160 acres, out to the Elochoman River; total cost was just under $2M. The county would not have been able to afford the project on their own, which involved replacement of the bridge. It took more than three years for site preparation. Project components include:

- Over 200,000 plants and shrubs were planted
- Filling of ditches that had captured the stream channel and creating a new channel in its historic location, while maintaining drainage across side channels
- Construction of the seismic-ready bridge
    - This was the costliest part of the project, and the most difficult because they needed to drill down 90 feet for the piles to support the bridge abutments and the bridge itself.

Nelson Creek. *Photo by Sam Shogren*

The discussion covered beavers potentially building dams and slowing water flow, though no major issues have been observed. One participant noted that local bobcats might be helping keep beaver impacts in check. The site supports diverse wildlife, including elk, otters, beavers, and both juvenile and adult salmon.

There were questions about channel migration; so far, when water backs up, it simply redirects into side channels rather than causing major changes. The area has significant sediment movement during high water events with sediment arriving from upstream. Sinks is monitoring the area and has not noticed any concern about sediment deposits impacting stream flow or the bridge.

Requests for bids for project work are shared with local and regional contractors, typically selected through a best-qualified, low-bid process. Experience–especially with conditions like tidal environments–is considered important in that process. Work is phased (such as spraying and planting), with efforts to include diverse and minority-owned crews, while ensuring contractors are properly licensed due to the sensitivity of fish habitat. In response to concerns about chemicals used in preparing the ground for planting, the team stated they use the least toxic herbicides available and avoid controversial insecticides.

2.5.3 Wahkiakum County Diking District 1 (Puget Island) Pumps

At the site, Tony Aegerter, diking district commissioner, provided a tour and explanation of the pumps and responded to questions.

The pump station moves ~12,000 gallons per minute. One station can potentially drain the entire island when operating at full capacity. Multiple pump stations work together for full system coverage. Pumps operate to about -2.5 ft below sea level, because going lower risks pumping groundwater, which is inefficient and costly. Heavy rain events (e.g., atmospheric rivers) are major design considerations and the system handles extreme rainfall due to capacity planning. Pumps are mostly inactive in summer (June until fall rains) because summer water levels often reach equilibrium naturally. They do occasionally run pumps briefly for testing or sub-irrigation support.

The main infrastructure dates back to ~1975. Replacement of older pipes is ongoing due to rust, scouring, and wear. Replacement projects cost roughly $80K–$100K each. Upgrades are phased, often every other year. Older systems rely on 1970s-era control panels and float-based automation. Pumps can operate automatically via float systems. There has been some interest in replacing mechanical floats with sonar-based systems because float systems can be vulnerable to wildlife (e.g., otters playing with floats). Maintenance includes ditch clearing, brush mowing, and debris removal. Trash racks must be maintained to prevent debris blockage, as debris (logs, driftwood) frequently enter the system. Maintenance equipment includes excavators, pickups, and heavy machinery (e.g., Caterpillar D5). The District shop is locally maintained with equipment storage and an operations base.

Tony Aegerter talks about the diking district pump house (left), interior of pump station (right). *Photos by Andrea Mah*

The annual budget is around ~$300K, with limited reserves (~$50K), meaning large repairs are financially significant. Infrastructure improvements often depend on staged funding and community support. Population growth increases the tax base, helping to fund operations. Work is supported by employees, contractors, and volunteers.

2.6 Lunch & Group Discussions

Lunches were catered by The Duck Inn, The Crippen Creek Inn, the Rosburg Community Club, and Maria's Place. At this point of the workshop, tables and chairs were rearranged for 4-6 people per table. Lunchtime was unstructured, allowing people to connect as they chose.


Lunch and desserts prepared by the Rosburg Community Club. *Photo by Jessica Vik*

Discussion activities varied from workshop to workshop.

2.6.1 Workshop 1 Discussion

Planning team members **Andrea Mah** and **Sandra Staples-Bortner** introduced the Workshop 1 activity. Andrea reviewed the goals of the discussions to: 1) engage in appreciative inquiry and identify assets related to the presentations and the visit to the marina and 2) identify opportunities for future resilience efforts. Sandra reviewed the *Principles to Achieve Multi-Benefit Watershed Restoration*, summarizing how the *Principles* came to be in the 2025 series, and reading the 'in summary' box on the last page. At tables, participants were asked to discuss and write responses on sticky notes to the following questions:

1. In what ways have you seen the Marina, the river, or nearby lands create benefits for:
    a. People of Wahkiakum County?
    b. The economy of Wahkiakum County?
    c. The local natural environment (like the fish, animals, plants, and waterways)?
    d. Resilience to hazards?
    e. Are any of these *new* benefits that should be included in the Wahkiakum Common Ground Principles?
2. Thinking about ideas for future resilience efforts that align with the Principles:
    a. What benefits are we trying to achieve?
    b. Which kinds of projects would help us achieve those benefits?
    c. What skills, knowledge, cultural background, or technical abilities are needed?

Attendees wrote their answers on sticky notes. Key themes from these notes are summarized below, with related responses from sticky notes shown in quotation marks:

1. In what ways have you seen the marina and nearby lands/waters create benefits for people, economy, environment, resilience to hazards? (41 responses)

- Improved public access to the river and marina for local residents and tourists

    - “Access to the river, which is connected to other communities, allows for hunting, fishing, birding, and boating access”
- Amenities being available like food vendors, bathrooms, upgraded campsites, BBQ shelter, and docks
- “Marina is a focal point in the community”
- Economic vitality is increased from outside money being brought in through events, camping, and tourism
    - “Kayakers! Boaters! Yacht club! Regattas!”
    - “Bringing in revenue from other areas - money velocity (= it moves $ in the economy)”
- Fishing, logging, and agriculture as key industries
    - “agriculture/timber (need to) balance with habitat benefits”
- Natural environment conservation/restoration improves habitat and fishing
    - “JBH refuge provides habitat”
    - “Nature as identity/way of life”

2. Thinking about ideas for future resilience efforts that align with the *Principles*: (23 responses)

a. What benefits are we trying to achieve?
    - Balanced outcomes for people and nature: Agriculture, fishing, flood reduction, and habitat all working together
    - Long-term watershed resilience and healthy full life cycles–protecting habitat for juvenile salmon rearing and adult salmon spawning; understanding watershed processes
    - Community unity, shared stewardship
        - “Projects that bring people together create networks”
    - Economic resilience
        - “Conservation and restoration are their own economic drivers”
    - Local community-led projects
    - Recognition of local resource values beyond sacrifice for “common good”

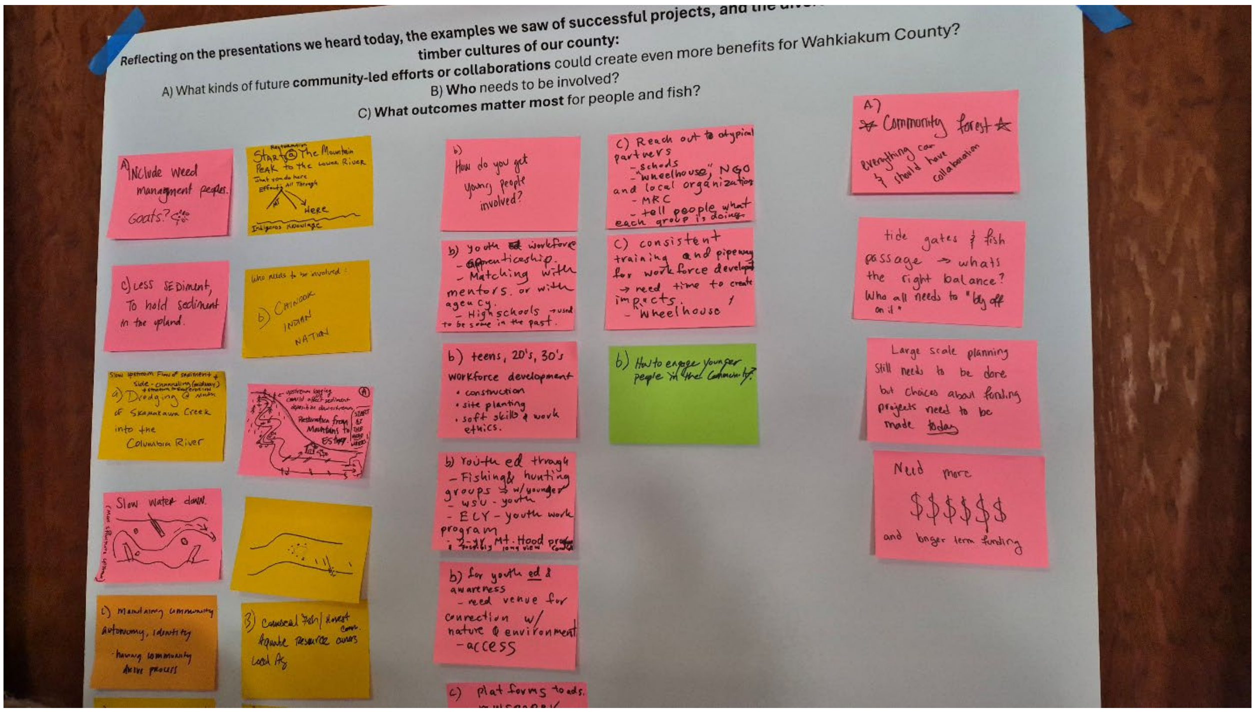
b. Which kinds of projects would help us achieve those benefits?
    - Helping Chinook Indian Nation to get federal recognition so that they have capacity to partner
    - Multi-benefit projects, e.g., “Farm, fish and flood”
    - Smarter infrastructure (emerging technologies)

c. What skills, knowledge, cultural background, or technical abilities are needed?
    - Open-mindedness and willingness to collaborate
    - Understanding of how much water is moving through these watersheds
    - Representatives from farming and timber to share cultural experience and local perspective
        - “Translating cultural background/identity of farming”
    - Thinking at watershed-scale

2.6.2 Workshop 2 Discussion

Andrea Mah introduced the discussion activity to the group as follows:

“You’ve heard from our speakers about salmon habitat needs, fisheries management, timber management, and seen examples of collaborative projects on Skamokawa Creek/Dead Slough and Nelson Creek. In the discussion, we want you to reflect on the past (including what we heard in Workshop 1 and today), and brainstorm ideas for the future. At your table, please have one person act as recorder, and use the provided sticky notes and Sharpies to capture your ideas.” The goal of this activity was to identify future projects that might serve as the basis for discussions at the subsequent workshops.



Ideas from Workshop 2. Photo by Andrea Mah

A major focus of the Planning Team was to ensure that these ideas were generated by attendees, and that they could be led by the community. The questions included:

1. Reflecting on the presentations we heard today, the examples we saw of successful projects, and the diverse tribal, fisheries, and timber cultures of our county:
    a. What kinds of future community-led efforts or collaborations could create even more benefits for Wahkiakum County?
    b. Who needs to be involved?
    c. What outcomes matter most for people and fish?

Summaries of discussions are provided below.

a. What kinds of future community-led efforts or collaborations could create even more benefits for Wahkiakum County?
    - Support the expansion of Vista Park
    - Support the creation of a community forest in the Upper Grays River watershed
    - Create health assessments of each watershed (e.g., habitat conditions, flows, concerns), including actions that could improve watershed resilience; Make them publicly available

- Continue Wahkiakum Common Ground as an ongoing and expanded forum for landowners and restoration practitioners to network and share resources
- Create a publicly-accessible flow chart of the agencies and nonprofits who are involved in watershed restoration and their roles
- Enhance monitoring and forecasting of flood impacts on the Grays River by seeking funding for rain gages in the upper watershed, improved flow gages downstream, and modeling of the river
- Enhance public access to private timberland for hunting, foraging, and enjoyment of nature, e.g. “Discovery Pass for Private Forestland”, “Foraging on private land”
- Support projects at the headwaters that can improve sediment deposition downstream, e.g., “slow water down (add more in-stream structures upstream)”
- Identify and promote local agricultural opportunities (e.g., farmer’s markets, local food initiatives, producer partnerships)
- Enhance resilience to flooding by expanding emergency preparedness (e.g., updating the Comprehensive Flood Hazard Mitigation Plan, working on improved warning and communication)
- Support the Chinook Indian Nation in their efforts to get federal recognition, and seek their input on watershed restoration projects
- Involve youth in our watersheds and natural resources by identifying or creating opportunities for education and workforce development
- Participate in or support the Voluntary Stewardship Program, which uses a voluntary (non-regulatory) approach to identify farm-friendly options for protecting fragile or hazardous natural resources
- Advocate for the expansion and sustained state funding of landowner incentive programs for voluntary habitat restoration activities (e.g., coalition-building, public outreach, legislative engagement, petitioning)
- Seek opportunities to enhance floodplain habitat while protecting nearby private land from flooding by replacing fixed tidegates with muted tidegate regulators
- Assess and identify strategies to enhance channel function and manage sediment buildup at the mouth of Skamokawa Creek into the Columbia River (e.g., dredging)

b. Who needs to be involved:

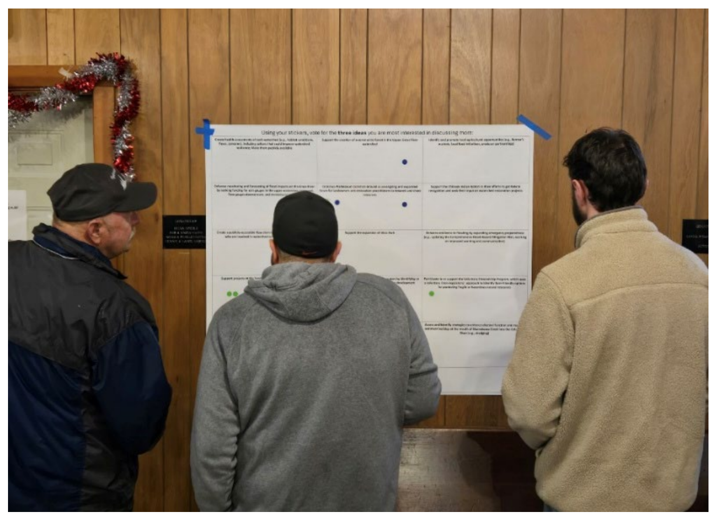
- The County
- Watershed Management Board
- USFWS
- Property owners
- Chinook Indian Nation
- Commercial fishers
- Young people/youth, schools
- Timber companies
- People with long-term older restoration projects
- International companies (forestry/logging)
- Port districts
- Birding groups
- Department of Natural Resources

c. What outcomes matter most for people and fish?

- “People, fish, and local survivability, sustainability”
- Public access to nature and natural resources
- “Maintaining community autonomy and identity”
- “Landowner agency and ownership”
- Public Health
- Education/awareness
- Multi-benefit outcomes
- Nature-based solutions
- Protection of private property

2.6.3 Workshop 3 Discussion

At Workshop 3, facilitators provided attendees with a list of the summarized ideas for future resilience-building activities that they had generated at Workshops 1 and 2 (Table 1). Before lunch, we asked attendees to use sticker dots to vote for the three projects they were most interested in spending time discussing. After lunch, tables were announced for the seven most popular ideas (shown bolded below; only six tables formed). Notes taken by tables from those discussions are transcribed in Appendix A.



Andrea Mah describes the activity (Left). Attendees vote on future activities to discuss at Workshop 3 (Right). *Photos by Jessica Vik*

Table 1. Future Activity Ideas and Votes

Idea	Votes
Continue Wahkiakum Common Ground as an ongoing and expanded forum for landowners and restoration practitioners to network and share resources	12
Support the creation of a community forest in the Upper Grays River watershed	11
Advocate for the expansion and sustained state funding of landowner incentive programs for voluntary habitat restoration activities (e.g., coalition-building, public outreach, legislative engagement, petitioning)	9
Create a publicly accessible flow chart of the agencies and nonprofits who are involved in watershed restoration and their roles	7
Support projects at the headwaters that can improve sediment deposition downstream	7
Participate in or support the Voluntary Stewardship Program, which uses a voluntary (non-regulatory) approach to identify farm-friendly options for protecting fragile or hazardous natural resources	6
Enhance resilience to flooding by expanding emergency preparedness (e.g., updating the Comprehensive Flood Hazard Mitigation Plan, working on improved warning and communication)	5
Involve youth in our watersheds and natural resources by identifying or creating opportunities for education and workforce development	5
Assess and identify strategies to enhance channel function and manage sediment buildup at the mouth of Skamokawa Creek into the Columbia River (e.g., dredging)	5
Support the expansion of Vista Park	4
Create health assessments of each watershed (e.g., habitat conditions, flows, concerns), including actions that could improve watershed resilience; Make them publicly available	4
Enhance monitoring and forecasting of flood impacts on the Grays River by seeking funding for rain gages in the upper watershed, improved flow gages downstream, and modeling of the river	4
Support the Chinook Indian Nation in their efforts to get federal recognition, and seek their input on watershed restoration projects	4
Seek opportunities to enhance floodplain habitat while protecting nearby private land from flooding by replacing fixed tidegates with muted tidegate regulators	2
Identify and promote local agricultural opportunities (e.g., farmer’s markets, local food initiatives, producer partnerships)	1

At each table, attendees were instructed to elect a notetaker and discuss:

1. What problems would this project address? What benefits would it have?
2. What motivates you to participate?
3. How do you see yourself and others here today contributing to advancing this project? Do any of you see yourself as a leader or co-leader of this effort?
4. What's one small thing that could be done in the next month to move this project forward?
5. Who else needs to be involved who wasn't present at the workshops?

After discussing, each table was asked to please share out <u>in one minute</u>: what's <u>one benefit</u> the project brings, what's <u>one small step</u> you see the group taking to get started.

- Community forest:
    - Benefit - public access for hunting, fishing, hiking, especially swimming in Fossil Creek
    - Small step - utilize the energy of this group to share information about the community forest publicly, spread the word about the benefits of the project
- Enhance resilience to flooding by expanding emergency preparedness:
    - Benefit - awareness. Making sure people know they are behind the dikes
    - Small step - GRFCD sends out postcards to members about maintenance issues with dikes, including information/links to websites. These could include information on flood risks and hazards.
- Support projects at the headwaters:
    - Benefit - reduce sediment deposition and flooding impacts in transitional zones and throughout watersheds
    - Small step - focus on finding and defining a problem statement so we can then understand the behavioral change that would support this activity and the motivation/'why' for it
- Create a publicly accessible flowchart:
    - Benefit - streamline referrals leading to happier landowners. More trust and engagement
    - Small step - Draft a conservation organization mission and service map at the next Common Ground.
- Advocate for expansion of sustained state funding of landowner incentive programs:
    - Benefit - (Re)build trust and encourage participation, especially after the CREP rollout/administration issues left some landowners feeling burned by contract cancellations and boundary reductions. Many rural landowners are land-rich but cash-poor. No specific next step was shared.
- Continue Wahkiakum Common Ground
    - Benefit - keep conversation going to expand the conservation benefits. Get people from lots of different experiences in the same room talking about a place they live in, love, and are concerned about. This table subtitled their project the youth movement. People are interested in succession planning.
    - Small step - reach out to superintendents that service Wahkiakum County, get them involved and to understand we want youth involved. Reach out to community colleges to find students who we can engage.

2.6.4 Workshop 4 Discussion

At Workshop 4, the goal of discussions was to provide more time for in-depth discussion of future activities, with a focus on identifying actionable next steps that people in the room could support. Each table had a specific set of questions relevant to the activity. These discussions were introduced as follows:

“Last time, we started discussing some ideas that might be moved forward with the help of people here. Today we want the activity to help keep that momentum. We aim to co-create realistic next steps, match projects with partners, expertise, or resources, and identify barriers that might stand in the way of these projects. Over the next hour or so, we will ask you to visit two different project tables. We’ll give you a warning when you need to switch. Each table will have someone who can help guide the discussion and take notes.

The overall goal of these tables is to set ourselves up for action, and to find people willing to take on responsibilities to help move things forward.”

Planning Team members served as table leaders. The future activities which were discussed differed slightly from the list that attendees voted on at the prior workshop. Because the focus was on projects at earlier stages, without clear momentum, the community forest activity (which is moving forward with lots of momentum) was not discussed. The Planning Team felt they could provide support for the creation of a publicly accessible flowchart of agencies and thus did not include it as a table. While it was not a specific activity that was included in prior workshops, there was feedback that there was a need for more visioning and big-picture thinking about the county. Youth involvement also came up in discussions across different future activity ideas. The final list of tables and activities discussed is provided below. Here we provide an overview of what each table leader shared, but the notes from discussions at Workshops 3 and 4 were compiled into a document shared back to attendees after the last workshop; see Appendix B: *Wahkiakum Common Ground 2026: Priority Topics.*

Support the Chinook Indian Nation in their efforts to get federal recognition and seek their input on watershed restoration projects - Table Leads: Hugh Ahnatook, Mechele Johnson, and Mary Johnson

Before the broader share out from each table happened, Hugh Ahnatook shared important updates from the Chinook Indian Nation:

- Hugh Ahnatook, a water steward working with CIN, along with Mechele Johnson, public relations for the Shoalwater Bay Indian Tribe, and Mary Johnson, culture coordinator for the CIN presented concerns about a proposed expansion of hunting and gathering territory by the Quinault Indian Nation.
- They believe this expansion would extend into the mouth of the Columbia River and surrounding areas (Chinook Indian Nation territory), potentially affecting local communities, economies, fisheries, and access to hunting and gathering resources. They argue it could also impact salmon habitats and upstream tribal and non-tribal fisheries.
- The group is encouraging public support for opposition efforts and circulated sign-up sheets and QR codes to gather community backing. They are also advocating for stronger recognition and support for the Chinook Indian Nation, suggesting that federal recognition could help bring funding for restoration, education, mental health, and other services to the region, including areas like Wahkiakum County.

- They describe forming alliances among regional tribes including Chinook, Chehalis, and Cowlitz groups, and are seeking support from non-tribal community members, including fishers and small businesses. They mentioned upcoming public meetings and updates, and the possibility of publishing a public column to share information and organize further.

Support projects at the headwaters to improve sediment deposition downstream - Table Lead: Steve West

- To summarize the problem in a few sentences, they came up with the statement that sediment moving down the river buries salmon redds and contributes to problems with erosion and flooding.
- They were interested in using direct experience (field trips, before/after photos of historic changes in the rivers and impacts of restoration) to raise awareness of these issues and make the argument more compelling
- Next steps:
    - **Isaac Holowatz** is willing to lead field trips for community members to observe watershed conditions directly
    - Additional field trips should be developed across rivers.
    - **Andrea Mah** could work on developing a one-pager about these specific impacts, draw on the PNNL report and reach out to Pete Barber (Cowlitz Indian Tribe) and others about finding documentation and photos of these impacts

Involve youth in our watersheds and natural resources by identifying or creating opportunities for education and workforce development - Table Lead: Carrie Shofner

- Youth engagement is important for long-term local capacity building.
- Outdoor education pathways that connect youth to the local environment and foster a sense of stewardship are needed.
- There is an opportunity to strengthen collaboration between schools, agricultural programs and community groups.
- Next steps:
    - **Tony Aegerter** will convene a meeting with interested participants and an FFA teacher to brainstorm next steps
    - People wanted to explore the development of an outdoor education program
    - Creating a "Wahkiakum Common Ground" youth edition might be one way to start

Carrie Shofner leads a discussion on youth engagement. *Photo by Sanpisa Sritrairat*

Enhance resilience to flooding by expanding emergency preparedness and mitigation actions - Table Lead: Jenna Tilt

- Community awareness is important to strengthen resilience, with a desire to reach newcomers to the county, the Latinx community, and other underrepresented communities
- Because existing resources are often underutilized, there need to be efforts to raise awareness of them, through collaboration with the fire district and emergency response partners
- Next steps:
    - **Mikaila Way, Austin Smith, and Ellen Chappelka** will have a conversation to coordinate efforts to connect resources with the Latino community in Wahkiakum County.
    - **Judy Johnson and Mia Giacondino** can coordinate outreach with the grange and develop speaking points
    - The GRFCD postcard will be distributed with maintenance reminders, and can be modified to include links to information about hazard preparedness/safety

Continue Wahkiakum Ground - Table Lead: Sandra Staples-Bortner

- There was interest in facilitated debates on topics like diking districts, tidegates, floodplains, hatchery operations, and economic impacts of watershed restoration
- People were interested in deeper conversations with more discussion of pros and cons
- Next steps:
    - Planning Team decide on key topics for MRC-funded workshops

Advocate for expansion of sustained state funding of landowner incentive programs, including supporting the Voluntary Stewardship Program - Table Lead: Brooke Bennett

- Wahkiakum Conservation District is doing a lot of work to reach local landowners, and this table talked a lot about different ways to reach more people: high visibility demonstration projects, site tours, provision of a ‘welcome to the county’ packet including information on WCD for newcomers, tabling at local events, and/or bulk mailers
- The table agreed that conversation and developing relationships is important to raise awareness of available resources and build trust
- Next steps:
    - Continue to raise awareness of VSP, through word of mouth, collaboration with WDFW and others who have frequent contact with landowners

Community Visioning: What would you like to see for the future of Wahkiakum County? - Table Lead: Sam Shogren

- The volunteer culture present in the county is important to keep everything functioning
- Economic development is important, creating opportunities so that people don’t leave the county
- Next steps:
    - **Sam Shogren** bring these notes back to Cowlitz Wahkiakum Council of Governments to consider in their planning processes

2.7 Closing Circles

At the end of each workshop, attendees were invited to stand in a circle around the room. At Workshops 1, 2, and 3, participants were asked to share one thing that resonated with them in one sentence. Common themes and examples of shared thoughts are provided below:

- Appreciation of collaboration, relationship-building, partnerships, and working together
    - “The importance of showing up to make progress on salmon recovery”
    - “At the table discussion there was discussion about how to reach outside the comfort zone to connect to organizations and have the opportunity for collaboration”
    - “Working and living with our neighbors, whether it’s fish at the mouth and everyone in between at the headwaters, all living and working together.”
    - “It’s beautiful to see everyone talking, laughing, exchanging ideas, hearing perspectives so I can learn”
    - “Good conversations and meeting more people”
- Listening across differences and expressing appreciation for the diversity of perspectives
    - “Being able to listen to everybody and hear what their issues are”
    - Analyzing all people and positions “makes me a better representative of the group here, I can actually speak in a position of knowing, rather than guessing which is a big benefit”
    - “The urban-rural divide, the need for new folks to get educated and for outsiders to understand where they are coming from”
- Seeing projects in action and appreciating results
    - On the tide gate seen at Workshop 2 “There were years of planning going into the whole system up to the inlet structure, it’s good to see that it’s functioning properly”
    - On seeing Nelson Creek project “Seeing it in progress in 2022 and now everything that’s been done, the concept that you can actually get out and do something, execute the plan”
- Awareness of the complexity of watershed restoration and the need for adaptive management
    - “Flexibility in coming to a solution”
    - “Muted tidegates are an example of common ground, neither side is super comfortable with the outcome, but it is a mediated outcome”
    - “A renewed and much deeper appreciation for how complex and interdependent all these various issues are”
- Learning, new understanding and appreciation of local context
    - “Hearing the great contextual history about the area and the Chinook Indian Nation from Chairman Johnson”
    - “I got a lot of context and history about places we drive by and over and don’t think about, but so much goes into the places, the tidegates, the bridge, so much goes into each of those sites”
    - “As a newer landowner to this area, these workshops are education for me, learning about the native species and working as a community to bring things back…”
    - “Salmon are our neighbors, not just natural resources for extraction”
- Long-term thinking and concern for future generations
    - “Honoring our past, recognizing the hurts behind us, but thinking ahead for juveniles (people and salmon)”
    - “The concept of deep time, generational thinking exemplified through Irene [Martin] and Tony [Johnson]’s talks”
    - “Youth are integral part of things moving forward”

- The desire for people not at the workshops to get involved and hear about Common Ground
    - “Need for senior agency management to be involved in this, that’s critical”
    - “That’s the most important thing, the knowledge shared here, I can go talk to someone else “
    - “I’m meeting a lot of people, getting new ideas and I’m hoping to take those back to the organizations I work with to spread the ideas”
- A desire for continued action and momentum
    - “How do we keep this going and realize some of the expectations and hopes and desires expressed today, through Common Ground “
    - “What we heard provides a really good groundwork for moving forward into more action-oriented stuff in future meetings”

At Workshop 4, participants were asked to share in one sentence: **In one year, what’s one thing you hope to be celebrating?**

- Greater connections with Latino/a people in the community
- Continued collaboration
- Strengthened partnerships
- Progress made towards building relationships and connections with Latino and Latina community members
- Federal recognition of the Chinook Indian Nation
- A spinoff of the Common Ground series in Oregon
- A youth-focused Common Ground series
- Continued relationship-building and opportunities to connect
- Progress made on topics discussed in the workshops
- Having reasons to come to Wahkiakum County that aren’t active disasters
- Successful implementation of ideas
- Continuation of Wahkiakum Common Ground that grows our circle even more
- Larger snowpack and better outlook for fish
- To not have to experience another flood
- Reaching out to federally elected officials, agency leaderships so that they know what we’re doing here
- Celebrating the success of Herm [Migliore]’s project
- Continuing conversations
- More community involvement, more participation
- Seeing less solitude and isolation and more collaboration
- Locals feeling more listened to by federal people
- A flowchart that helps residents understand chains of authority
- Progress on the Grays River community forest
- Groups coming together to work on the potential projects
- Increased emergency preparedness
- That the Marine Resources Committee budget is not cut
- Ideas becoming reality
- A 2027 workshop series

3. Series Takeaways

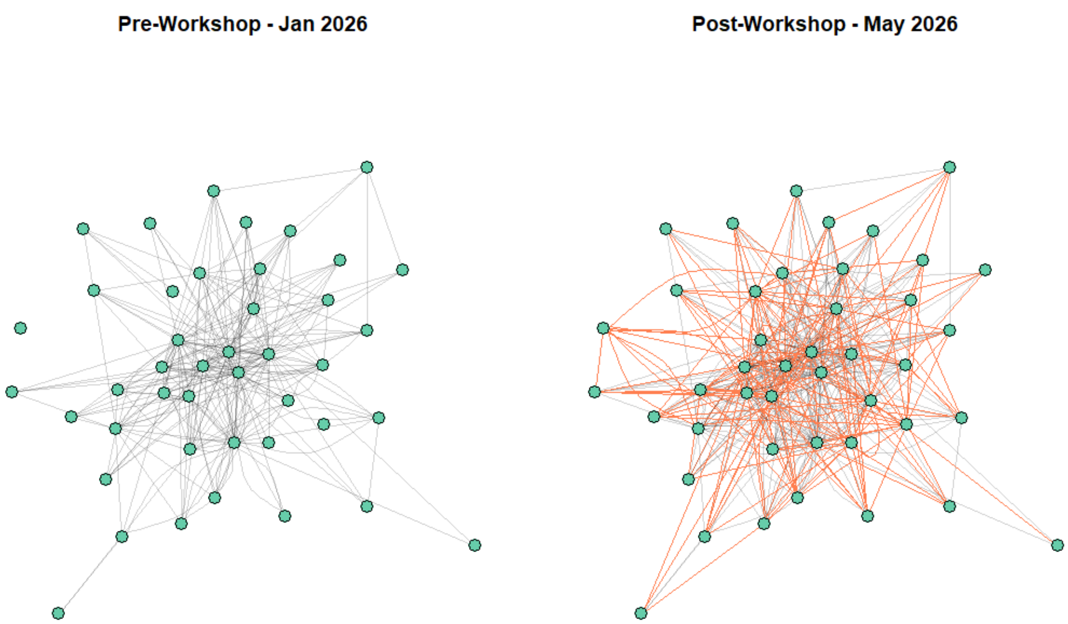
3.1 Outcomes of the Wahkiakum Common Ground 2026 Workshops

In addition to the pre- and post-workshop evaluations completed by participants, the Planning Team reflected on the workshops and outcomes we observed. Here we provide a brief summary of findings.

Strengthened and created new relationships

- Representatives from 36 different organizations were present at the workshops, and 69 people total took part in at least one workshop.
    - Social network analysis was used to examine the links between organizations, as measured by personal connections to organizations reported by survey participants. Before the workshops, there were 255 ties reported; after the workshops, there were 458, representing an increase of 203 connections.

Figure 3. Wahkiakum Common Ground Organizational Network



Each node represents an organization or individual, each line represents a reported connection. **Orange lines represent new connections.**

Knowledge and understanding of watershed restoration and flood mitigation projects and processes

- There was a statistically significant increase in agreement with the statement “I am aware of projects to address flood risk currently happening in Wahkiakum County”

- Closing circles often included reflection on new things people had learned, and the value of educational components
- New educational materials were developed. As part of the CoPes Hub pilot grant, one-pagers for projects highlighted in the 2025 workshop series were designed and distributed, with the Wahkiakum Common Ground website (beav.es/WCG) serving as a way to document and share the 'success stories' and products created from the 2025 and 2026 workshop series
- Participants were already supportive of projects that simultaneously address watershed restoration and flood mitigation. While statistically significant shifts in agreement were not observed, the changes trended in expected directions (e.g., decreased agreement with the statement that such projects 'limit the effectiveness of fish habitat restoration and flood mitigation' and increased agreement with the statement that these projects 'open up more funding opportunities')
- Before and after workshops, participants rated dredging or deepening river channels as the least effective way to reduce flood risk in the county and rated increasing or restoring vegetation buffers near rivers/streams as the most effective strategy. No significant changes in beliefs about the efficacy of strategies was observed.

Nelson Creek Site Visit. *Photo by Sanpisa Sritrairat*

Shared priorities to inform future efforts

- Participants in the workshops already prioritized the goals guiding the workshops.
    - Before the workshops, the top three priorities (based on average ratings) were:
        - Improving emergency preparedness to coastal hazards associated with heavy rainfall and other natural disasters
        - Restoring local watersheds and salmon habitat
        - Reducing flooding and erosion of private and public infrastructure
    - After the workshops, the top three priorities were:

        - Boosting the economic vitality of the county
        - Reducing flooding and erosion of private and public infrastructure
        - Restoring local watersheds and salmon habitat
    - There were statistically significant increases in the prioritization of these goals:
        - Boosting the economic vitality of the county
        - Preserving the historic character of the county
- Participants participated in discussions about seven projects/efforts that Wahkiakum Common Ground could support, see section 2.6.4.
    - Conversations on some of these topics have continued since the workshops, such as connections between representatives of Emergency management (local and state) and Consejo Hispano
    - The Grays River Flood Control District included the county's emergency management information, including Austin Smith's contact information, on postcards distributed to their mailing list, an idea that was shared in a small group discussion on improving emergency resilience.
- 96% of post-workshop survey respondents were interested in participating in some format of follow-up conversations with Common Ground attendees, in the form of coffee/social hours or online meetings.

Spread of awareness and ideas

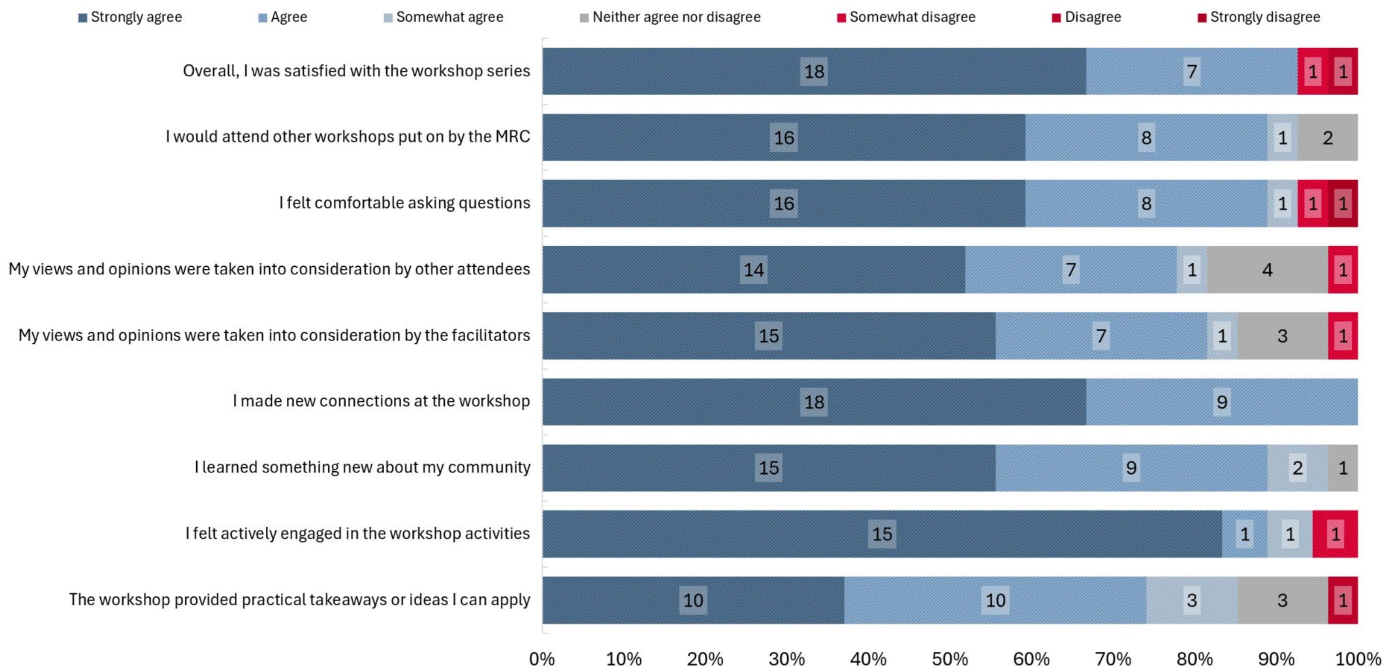
- 96% of participants (27/28) reported that they had shared something about the workshops with someone who did not participate. For example:
    - "I have shared with people (both work and social contacts) about this workshop series by framing it as a unique happening and one intrinsically linked to/made possible by the small community size and high degree of engagement among local citizens. I've also linked the Story Map page to many people (especially prospective project partners or landowners) as a catch-all source for good past project summaries and photos."
- Planning Team members have heard anecdotally that Common Ground has influenced other efforts in the county (e.g., more people reaching out to the Conservation District), and people outside the community are aware of these efforts
    - In September 2026, a Ripple Effects Mapping exercise is planned to document impacts of the workshop beyond immediate outcomes
- Other practitioners interested in community engagement have reached out to members of the Planning Team to learn more about the approach
    - Presentations on the workshop approach and evaluation have been given at the Coastal Hazards Resilience Network (CHRN) annual meeting (May 2026), the annual meeting of the International Association for Society and Natural Resources (IASNR, June 2026), and the Community Development Society annual conference (July 2026).
- Wahkiakum Common Ground was awarded the *Innovative Program Award* from the Community Development Society (July 2026)
- Wahkiakum Common Ground Planning Team was awarded the *Organization of the Year Award* from the Washington Department of Fish and Wildlife, Southwest Region 5 (July 2026)

Positive workshop impressions

- Participants were asked to rate their agreement with statements about their workshop experience, see Figure 4.

- Overall, 92% of participants agreed that they were satisfied with the workshop series, and many positive comments were provided in the survey, for example: “each workshop keeps getting better and better and can't wait for the 3rd year!” and “Thank you all for your skilled facilitation and coordination, these are needed conversations and spaces for collaboration."

Figure 4. Workshop perceptions.



3.2 Limitations

While there were many positive impacts of the workshops, some changes we hoped to see were not observed. In the evaluation, this included:

- No significant increase in agreement (from ‘neither agree nor disagree’) with the statement ‘In the past ten years, collaborative efforts in Wahkiakum County have been successful’ despite the sharing of multiple successful projects
- No change in perceptions ‘there are significant barriers to collaboration in Wahkiakum County the average agreement was between neither agree nor disagree and somewhat agree both before and after the survey.
- Participants were asked to share their level of interest or involvement in supporting future efforts (e.g., helping with vegetation management, monitoring, construction, or building capacity). Across these four categories of ways to support this work, more people decreased in their reported level of willingness or involvement for helping with vegetation management, helping to build or maintain infrastructure, and helping to monitor efforts than increased their willingness or involvement. This may relate to observations that in discussing future activities, people seemed to be not very willing to volunteer to take on leadership roles for those activities.
- No significant changes in self- or collective efficacy were observed, perhaps because people already had a strong sense of efficacy. While people disagreed more strongly that “there is

nothing we can do to reduce risks from flooding in Wahkiakum County" after the workshops, they already disagreed with this statement prior to the workshop. Similarly, people agreed before and after the workshop that they "feel confident in [their] ability to advocate for changes that are important to [them] in Wahkiakum County."

3.3 Planning team reflections and lessons learned

Planning team members shared their reflections on the series, including things that went well and things that might be improved in the future.

Positives:

- Increased participation from more people and groups beyond natural resource or emergency management agencies and NGOs (e.g., more landowners, the Chinook Indian Nation, Consejo Hispano)
- Continued and consistent participation seems to be key to success - momentum has built over the past two years.
- The format of the workshops (e.g., guest speakers, field trips, time for small and large group discussions) has been refined over time and seems to run well
- Allowing for more discussion time allows for greater depth of conversation
- Presentations and field trips seem to have had a substantial ripple effect, with people referencing things they learned from them outside the context of the workshops
- Sharing responsibilities among the Planning Team helped the days run smoothly

Areas for improvement:

Agenda setting & timing

- At times during the workshops, the agenda felt rushed. There was a desire by participants to ask guest speakers more questions and dive deeper into the discussion. Having fewer speakers or increasing the workshop length might allow for more time for question and answer, and more unstructured time that is crucial for networking.
- Discussions of future activities varied in their depth and level of actionable steps, with some tables running out of time before getting through the discussion questions. More time for discussion might help.
    - There are tradeoffs between providing more time for discussion and maintaining the educational component. Education is key to building the basis for productive conversations but takes time.

Representation

- Capacity of workshop locations seems to be a limiting factor and some people who were interested in attending the workshop series had to be turned away. However, increasing the number of participants has potential tradeoffs. Would the workshop series be able to achieve the same level of relationship-building? And there are limited spaces in the county to accommodate larger numbers of participants. Social hours and more regular meetings - which survey respondents were interested in - might help bring more people into the conversation without diminishing opportunities to build relationships.

- Representation from timber companies was lacking, but a desire for their participation came up repeatedly.

Fulfilling the mission of Common Ground

- The Planning Team believes that the role of Common Ground is to convene county residents and stakeholders and facilitate productive, collaborative discussions regarding key issues in the county that lead to implementable actions. However, the workshop discussion activities revealed limited willingness of participants to take leadership roles to facilitate the implementation of potential projects discussed. Future workshops should identify ways that will empower participants to take on these leadership roles, and workshop convenors and facilitators need to be cognizant of allowing new leaders to emerge and not take on roles beyond their capacity. Increasing engagement—especially among younger participants—could expand future leadership and mentoring opportunities. Although the pathway from education to action is still emerging, the impacts of Wahkiakum Common Ground may become more visible as participants collaborate more over time. The Ripple Effects Mapping session planned for September 2026 may help reveal these developments.
- Some attendees would like to see a debate or space that is not only focused on positives when considering natural resource and hazard mitigation planning. The Planning Team is unsure whether this is their role: debates require fact-checking and clear rules of engagement. Furthermore, debates typically are seen in terms of winners and losers, rather than seeking out nuances of complex issues that are not straightforward. However, acknowledging negatives of complex issues provides space for a wide range of perspectives and can help achieve future common ground and pathways. In future presentations, site visits and discussions, the Planning Team will encourage guest speakers and all participants to more clearly articulate the tradeoffs in issues they have been involved in–speaking to both positive and negative–and encourage discussions about how common ground was reached. In other words, how were tradeoffs between the positive and negative reached and what lessons could be learned for future collaborations.

As a result of the outcomes shared here and positive feedback from participants, the Wahkiakum County Marine Resources Committee awarded funding to hold fall and winter 2026 Wahkiakum Common Ground workshops. This award signals ongoing support for the initiative and affirms its importance to the community's future work.

Appendix A. Transcribed Notes from Workshop 3 Future Activities Discussion

Project: Continue Wahkiakum Common Ground + Youth Movement

Total votes: 11

Names: Sam Shogren, Jackson Blalock, Mia Giacondino, Irene Martin, Megan Blackburn-Friend

1) **What problems would this project address? What benefits would it have?**
- Improved communication, info sharing, a broad spectrum of interests and backgrounds
- How can we keep convening Common Ground to help seed the community w/ Ideas for projects to improve our community
- Brings new & old residents together + silos break down
- Common ground helps us share knowledge

2) **What motivates you to participate**
    - How do we bring the next generation into dialogue and help perpetuate this work - mentorship/succession planning
    - To share my knowledge + mentor youths + younger professionals
    - Connection between youth experience + adult career
    - The need to build community through volunteerism
    - I learned how incredible a community can be if it starts with intention

3) **How do you see yourself and others here today contributing to advancing this project? Do any of you see yourself as a leader or co-leader of this effort?**
    - Sharing the experience by getting the word out

4) **What's one small thing that could be done in the next month to move this project forward?**
    - Mapping out a vision of what needs doing in the community
    - Working through "WHEELhouse" + getting UW students landscape + design students here to help -- Wahkiakum.org

5) **Who else needs to be involved who isn't present at the workshops?** Education providers
    - Superintendents
    - Lower Columbia College
    - Clatsop College

Project: Advocate for the expansion and sustained state funding of landowner incentive programs for voluntary habitat restoration activities (e.g., coalition-building, public outreach, legislative engagement, petitioning)

Total votes: 9

Names: Kent Martin, Jon Thompson

1) **What problems would this project address? What benefits would it have?**
    - Attach a value to a rural source of wealth
    - Help bridge the urban rural divide
    - No value attached to fisheries and the families who depend upon them

2) **What motivates you to participate**
    - The fishery is my life's work

3) **How do you see yourself and others here today contributing to advancing this project? Do any of you see yourself as a leader or co-leader of this effort?**
    - Just being here
4) **What's one small thing that could be done in the next month to move this project forward?**
    - Affirmation by the state that fish have value to rural communities beyond recreational opportunity
5) **Who else needs to be involved who isn't present at the workshops?**
    - Senior fisheries agency representation, both state and federal

Project: Create a publicly accessible flow chart of the agencies and non-profits who are involved in watershed restoration and their roles

Total votes: 7

Names: Kay Walters, Jay Horita, Rachael Barry

1) **What problems would this project address? What benefits would it have?**
    - Public awareness, many agencies, no clear point-people
    - Landowner feeling support, knowing how to navigate
    - Good employee/partner training
2) **What motivates you to participate**
    - Tired of being the navigator
    - Make better referrals, not step on toes
    - Understand priorities
    - Benefit: streamlined referrals leads to happier landowners, higher level trust & engagement
3) **How do you see yourself and others here today contributing to advancing this project? Do any of you see yourself as a leader or co-leader of this effort?**
    - Plant seeds of cooperation. The common ground experience
    - Resource mapping
    - Good leaders might be Extension as convener
4) **What's one small thing that could be done in the next month to move this project forward?**
    - Next Common Ground draft a 'conservation organization' mission/service map
    - Resource provider: Contractor ID research
5) **Who else needs to be involved who isn't present at the workshops?**
    - Marshall Blanchert
    - Restoration contractors
    - Equipment folks
    - Ag teachers/CTE
    - Emergency management
    - Music & entertainment!

Project: Support the creation of a community forest in the Upper Grays River watershed

Total votes: 11

Names: Dan Cothren, Brad Bortner, Adam Fletcher, Jack Giacondino, Isaac Holowatz, Brooke Bennett

1) **What problems would this project address? What benefits would it have?**
    - Public access

- Recreation
- Harvest practice
- County income
- Community control

2) **What motivates you to participate**
    - Swim in Fossil Creek
    - Access for hunting, fishing, hiking
3) **How do you see yourself and others here today contributing to advancing this project? Do any of you see yourself as a leader or co-leader of this effort?**
    - Leader w/ Dan
4) **What's one small thing that could be done in the next month to move this project forward?**
    - Publicity and sharing w/in the community
5) **Who else needs to be involved who isn't present at the workshops?**
    - Current landowners

Project: Enhance resilience to flooding by expanding emergency preparedness (e.g., updating the Comprehensive Flood Hazard Mitigation Plan, working on improved warning and communication)

Total votes: 5

Names: Tony Aegerter, Donny Dyer, Lance Britt, Paula Culbertson, Mikaila Way, Sandra Staples-Bortner, Jenna Tilt

1) **What problems would this project address? What benefits would it have?**
    - Awareness - not everyone knows they are behind a dike and at risk, may not know the way out in an emergency
    - CFHMP is an element of the comprehensive plan that is now being updated. Current is 1980
    - Tsunami warning system has recently been updated, and Wahkiakum is now at risk
    - Airbnb - need evacuation plans for visitors
    - Want to include voices from throughout the county
    - Do residents understand the risk of living behind a dike?
2) **What motivates you to participate**
    - Survival; we all have boats/need boats; increase level of awareness of the risks
    - Fire dept is responsible for evacuating people
    - We need a manual for who is responsible
3) **How do you see yourself and others here today contributing to advancing this project? Do any of you see yourself as a leader or co-leader of this effort?**
    - Word of mouth transfer of information
    - GRFCD Diking district sends out postcards re: dike maintenance, perhaps they could help distribute info re: when/how to evacuate, refer them to DOE website re: flooding
    - County Dept of Emergency Management has plans/materials we could help distribute information
    - Different expertise in different areas of county
4) **What's one small thing that could be done in the next month to move this project forward?**
    - GRFCD - postcards to district members
    - Puget Island Diking District - put info on website or postcard
5) **Who else needs to be involved who isn't present at the workshops?**
    - Fire Dept

- Diking Districts
- County Department of Emergency Management
- Local farmers

Project: Projects at headwaters to improve sediment deposition downstream

Total votes: 7

Names: Katie Pierson, Ben Newman, Ashley Smithers, Bryce Glaser

1) **What problems would this project address? What benefits would it have?**
    - Improve sediment deposition (decrease) downstream
    - Improve/reduce flooding impacts
    - Improve fish habitat by capturing sediments upstream
    - Transitional zone support
    - Improves forest health overall
2) **What motivates you to participate**
    - Trying to address some of the problems first as opposed to the symptom
    - < landowners - brings landowners that are not normally involved into this ecosystem health conversation
    - Ecosystem health in entire watershed
    - Holistic
    - Takes some of the pressure off the floodplain/wetland restoration projects - hard to show immediate improvement
    - Bigger blocks of land
3) **How do you see yourself and others here today contributing to advancing this project? Do any of you see yourself as a leader or co-leader of this effort?**
    - Common ground as support network, educate folks on the value rather than facilitating the actual projects (not project sponsors)
    - Common ground can make the argument in the community for greater watershed health
    - What does support mean?
        - Community forest is a pilot project? Getting more people involved at local level.
    - Support → education and bringing more people to the table. Needs leadership not directly from Common Ground
    - Community residents need to move it forward w/ organization support team as well
4) **What's one small thing that could be done in the next month to move this project forward?**
    - Identify key components in each watershed - key landowners, key players
        - Create a flowchart of local entities
        - Start advancing a watershed health assessment
    - Define message or problem statement
    - What is the actual source of behavioral change that would help support this type of project
    - Understand the why and the how we got here
5) **Who else needs to be involved who isn't present at the workshops?**
    - Large timber owners & forest practice folks
    - Cowlitz Indian Tribe
    - YOUTH

Appendix B. Priority Topics Summary

Wahkiakum Common Ground 2026: Priority Topics

This document summarizes discussions about future activities at Wahkiakum Common Ground 2026.

- **At workshop 2** we asked: What kinds of future **community-led efforts or collaborations** could create even more benefits for Wahkiakum County?
- **At workshop 3** we voted on the list of ideas that emerged from those questions. Then, we split into tables to discuss individual ideas to answer the following questions:
  - What problems would this project address? What benefits would it have?
  - What motivates you to participate?
  - How do you see yourself and others here today contributing to advancing this project? Do any of you see yourself as a leader or co-leader of this effort?
  - What's one small thing that could be done in the next month to move this project forward?
  - Who else needs to be involved who isn't present at the workshops?
- **At workshop 4** we revisited these ideas to discuss in greater depth what the **next steps** of each project were; **who was willing to take responsibility** for those next steps; and **how common ground participants could support them**.

We used the notes collected from table discussions, share outs, and reflections from table leaders to create summaries. Thank you to everyone who participated in these conversations. We hope the commitments and connections made during the discussions continue to grow through future follow-up and support.

Topics
Enhance resilience to flooding by expanding emergency preparedness and mitigation actions
Support projects at the headwaters to improve sediment deposition downstream
Continue Wahkiakum Common Ground
Involve youth in our watersheds and natural resources by identifying or creating opportunities for education and workforce development
Advocate for expansion of sustained state funding of landowner incentive programs, including supporting the Voluntary Stewardship Program
Community Visioning: What would you like to see for the future of Wahkiakum County?
Support the Chinook Indian Nation in their efforts to get federal recognition and seek their input on watershed restoration projects
Create a publicly accessible flow chart of the agencies and non-profits who are involved in watershed restoration and their roles

Enhance resilience to flooding by expanding emergency preparedness and mitigation actions

Strengthening community resilience in Wahkiakum County depends on connecting residents, local groups, and county emergency management. This means not only reaching out to people, but also making sure they know where to find resources, how to follow emergency protocols, and who to contact during an event.

Some communities are left out of planning and communication, including Latinx and Russian residents, as well as people who rely on the food bank. Public information needs to be available in multiple languages, along with access to translation services such as dispatch link/language link.

New homeowners and prospective buyers also need clear information about floodplains and dikes, what actions they can take on their property, and what resources exist. Flood insurance guidance is especially important for homeowners and renters, as are flood risk disclosures and evacuation guidance for renters. Realtors play a key role in sharing this information. Livestock owners in fire- and flood-prone areas also need targeted outreach.

Increasing public understanding of the following topics would be especially helpful:

- Emergency protocols
- Necessary supplies and tools
- Emergency contacts
- Dos and don’ts for different types of emergencies
- Resources for livestock owners
- Chain of command and agency responsibilities
- Available communication tools:
    - HAM radio
    - AM/FM radio
    - Hyper Reach

One way to reach more residents is to share emergency information, resource packets, kits, and contact numbers through local organizations, such as:

- American Legion
- Food Bank
- Senior Lunches
- Johnson Park
- Skamokawa Grange
- Grays River Grange
- Wahkiakum County Fair
- Bunko and sewing groups

Another strategy is to build neighborhood networks or “cells,” potentially with designated emergency stewards. These groups would understand local needs and coordinate with their fire districts and stations. Rural areas, in particular, face higher risks of isolation. These stewards are known and trusted among their group (like Mia who has volunteered to pass on information to the grange–see below).

However, they need support in knowing what information needs to be passed on, resources to distribute, etc.

Workshops could help residents assemble emergency supplies or smaller kits, practice scenarios, and identify what they already have that could be useful in an emergency.

Finally, mapping and sharing information about flood and fire evacuation routes and high-risk areas would support better preparedness across the county.

Next Steps:

- **Grays River Flood Control District** is mailing out a postcard soon that will remind all district participants of the timing window to maintain and clean up ditches, and repair dike holes, breaches, and tidegates. **Judy Johnson** will also include information on safety resources and a workshop on the postcard, and work with **Austin Smith** on this for the postcard. **We can support them by coming to help with the workshop.**
- **Mia Giacondino and Judy Johnson** will talk to the Granges about emergency preparedness and work with **Austin Smith** on resources and information to share.
- **Austin Smith** will pursue keys to the logging roads in Eden Valley for emergency exit and help with other items as identified here. **We can support him by helping secure more funding for this work and growing collaborations across the GRFCD and Granges. Sam Shogren** will pursue including emergency egress in the transportation resiliency plan currently under development by the Cowlitz-Wahkiakum **Council of Governments - the region's transportation planning organization.**
- **Ellen Chappelka** will check on the Hazard Mitigation Plan (HMP) process.
- **Mikaila Way, Austin Smith and Ellen Chappelka** will put their heads together to grow connections across the Latinx community, Emergency Management, and Fire Stations in Wahkiakum County. We can support them by helping with introductions.

Support projects at the headwaters to improve sediment deposition downstream

Upper watershed sediment sequestration provides coho and steelhead spawning and rearing habitat. If large quantities of sediment are allowed to move downstream, it is a major detriment to mainstem spawners. At workshop 3, participants talked about the benefits of these projects:

- Reducing sediment deposition downstream, which improves fish habitat
- Reducing flood impacts on downstream landowners
- Improved forest health

Supporting projects at the headwaters helps lead to improved ecosystem health holistically and addresses root problems rather than treating symptoms. Educating the community and creating a clear message were ways that participants thought Common Ground could support these efforts.

At workshop 4, participants came up with the following problem statements to help describe the issue and need for projects at the headwaters to someone outside Wahkiakum Common Ground:

Sediment moving downstream buries redds (the gravel beds where salmonids lay their eggs) and contributes to flooding by elevating the streambed and increasing the velocity of floodwaters. Flooding and erosion are huge issues as a result of sedimentation. The upper and lower watersheds are connected through natural processes, and we cannot plan our way out of flooding and sedimentation issues through lower watershed management alone. These are headwater-driven problems.

To help others understand the problem, we can share the following kinds of evidence:

- **Current and historic photos and videos** to help people compare and understand the impacts of sedimentation
- **Before and after photos and videos of restoration projects** to show their positive impacts, with an emphasis on highlighting how fish restoration projects result in flood mitigation
- **The Grays River Watershed Geomorphic Analysis report** from Pacific Northwest National Laboratory (2005, https://www.pnnl.gov/main/publications/external/technical_reports/PNNL-16494.pdf?__hstc=249664665.e7719ac716ae58345d90d634ae0ec2d3.1777652884543.1777652884543.1777652884543.1&__hssc=249664665.1.1777652884543&__hsfp=0ab20468b4ee2f7f6f3d60ef72c0c345)
- **Documentation of or visits to the closed Grays River Hatchery**, which exemplifies direct impacts of sedimentation

Next steps:

- Work to develop a consistent message that can be easily distributed
  - Identify what kinds of outreach has already been happening around garnering support for projects at the headwaters
  - **Andrea Mah** can work on a one-pager that summarizes the problem with lots of photos and should connect with Cowlitz Indian Tribe, Columbia Land Trust and others who might have access to useful photos that illustrate the problem. The work in Abernathy Creek may also be a good example.
  - Develop a PowerPoint or other short report or memo that draws on the PNNL report and photos to describe the problem
- Work with Wahkiakum Conservation District (particularly the Voluntary Stewardship Program, **Brooke Bennett**), Columbia Land Trust, & Washington Department of Fish and Wildlife to figure out how to distribute the consistent message.
- Find ways to ensure that projects at the headwaters are considered as part of the Comprehensive Flood Hazard Mitigation Plan
- Organize field trips to educate people (including youth) about this issue - **Sandra Staples-Bortner & Isaac Holowatz**
- **Find ways to connect with others who weren't at the workshops:** Large timber owners, small-landowner forestry practitioners, and youth

Continue Wahkiakum Common Ground

Ideas for topics/themes for future Wahkiakum Common Ground workshops focused around forest practices, economic drivers, youth engagement, fisheries and community outreach and networking.

- **Forest practices**: Invite speakers like Stephan Dillon from Manulife, Jason Walters from Weyerhaeuser and Brian Weisman from Department of Natural Resources.

- **Economic drivers:** Learn about impact of salmon recovery dollars to community, recreational fishery, construction/restoration companies involved in fish restoration, employment for young people and others. Learn more about local economic development drivers and the challenges they face, e.g. Port 1, Port 2, Chamber of Commerce, Washington Department of Commerce, and Army Corps dredge spoils.
- **Youth engagement:** Connect with the high schools, 4-H and Future Farmers of America (FFA).
- **Fisheries:** Learn about Beaver Creek Hatchery and how it works. Learn about the pound nets on the Columbia River, their operation and purpose as a select harvest fishery for commercial fishers.
- **Community Outreach:** Education is percolating out into the county; how do we extend the reach of WCG to more of the community? The "Blackfoot Challenge" in Montana is a good example for Wahkiakum Common Ground to learn from.

We could also spend more time learning about **diking districts** and the **water systems and wastewater systems** in the county.

We could move our dialogue even deeper, having a **facilitated debate on issues** like muted tide gates, dikes, floodplains, channels -- really digging into issues that have been guarded. A facilitator can help with conflict that comes with tough conversations.

Resources to help with workshop costs could be to ask Weyerhaeuser and Manulife to sponsor future workshops. Also, maybe we don't have to do site visits – this would save on costs.

Next Steps:

- A next step could be a session on Wahkiakum Common Ground at a County Commission meeting. An evening session around Wahkiakum Common Ground could be held in partnership with Wahkiakum County.

Involve youth in our watersheds and natural resources by identifying or creating opportunities for education and workforce development

Ideas for expanding education and workforce development include:

- **Support teachers in using local environments as learning spaces**, similar to Lincoln County, Oregon, by helping them align field trips with educational standards.
- **Create a youth version of Wahkiakum Common Ground** in schools, with speakers, field trips, and problem-solving discussions. The Columbia River Intertribal Fish Commission's salmon camp offers a model. Local trips—such as visiting diking districts, dairy farms, or foraging sites—could be organized with help from Wahkiakum Common Ground participants.
- **Develop a Green Workforce program** in Wahkiakum and Pacific Counties, modeled after the program in Forks, Washington. Students could gain paid experience in restoration, invasive species removal, and related work. Partners could include Pacific Education Institute, 10,000 Years Institute, state agency apprenticeships, and local Conservation Districts, which already run

internships and apprenticeships. Shared coordination across agencies could strengthen these opportunities.

- **Build a youth outdoor mentoring program** or connect with the existing Wahkiakum Community Network program. The main goal would be consistent time outdoors with adult mentors, with recruitment supported by Wahkiakum Common Ground participants.
- **Collaborate with ESD112, WSU Extension, and school districts** on the REACH summer and after-school program to expand outdoor opportunities such as camping and day trips.
- **Support ongoing school-based outdoor learning**, including work by Wahkiakum School District staff and the new FFA outdoor learning center developed with the Chinook Indian Nation.
- **Engage youth in hands-on environmental work**, such as invasive species removal or pike minnow fishing, which have been successful in the past.
- **Explore existing outdoor and environmental programs**, such as OMSI outdoor school or aquaculture-related opportunities.

Key questions moving forward:

- How do we reach the growing number of homeschooled youth, who can access school programs but may not be connected to them?
- How do we build programs that are consistent and long-term rather than one-off experiences?
- How do we create clear college and career pathways, including summer training for high school and college students?
- How do we design programs that fit into busy high school schedules and align with students' interests?

Next Steps:

- **Tony Aegerter** will arrange to have **Carrie Shofner** speak at the next Future Farmers of America (FFA) Advisory Board meeting to see if Wahkiakum Common Ground might support the school's work on the Farm Forest (forest owned by the school) and outdoor education.
- If math/physical science can be part of learning experiences, there may be ways the CRITFC project team can help. They do numerical modeling of river discharge flows to predict flooding etc. (**Tawnya Peterson**).

Advocate for expansion of sustained state funding of landowner incentive programs, including supporting the Voluntary Stewardship Program

Programs that help attach value to a rural source of wealth (land) are important to support fisheries and the families who depend on them. Helping support these programs for voluntary habitat restoration might involve coalition-building activities, legislative engagement, and petitioning. The **Voluntary Stewardship Program** (VSP) offers a pathway to provide benefits to landowners in the county, and is a program that uses watershed-focused, incentive-based voluntary collaboration to protect critical areas for conservation. Anyone who does agricultural activities that intersect with critical areas can participate. The program is run through the Wahkiakum Conservation District by **Brooke Bennett.**

Barriers to participation in VSP and other programs include:

- **Lack of awareness** of available services and programs, particularly among newcomers
- **Outstanding questions about costs** or loss of use of land
- **Timelines** required for grants do not always align with landowner needs
- **Distrust** from past experiences with programs like the Conservation Reserve Enhancement Program (CREP)

Communicating about these efforts helps avoid misunderstandings. To reach people and raise awareness of VSP and other programs we can use social media, mass mailers, and high visibility demonstration projects. People agreed that face to face connections are more likely to get people to participate because showing up is important in Wahkiakum County. Connections like these can be made by going to existing meetings, tabling at the County Fair or Bald Eagle Days. When we talk to people about VSP, we should make sure to highlight the ways that it benefits landowners – how it can address problems that landowners face.

Next Steps:

- **Wahkiakum Conservation District** will continue with education and outreach to ensure that everyone in the county is aware of available programs to address their resource concerns.
    - **Brad Bortner** is willing to host a show & tell presentation
    - **Brooke Bennett** will reach out to Isaac Holowatz and others who have a lot of contacts with landowners about providing some kind of VSP handouts/materials
    - Taking part in the county-wide Conservation Roundtables hosted bimonthly by Commissioner Dan Cothren
    - Host a community potluck, a coffee/social hour because "the best conversations happen over a coffee or beer"
    - Connecting with real estate agents and the Chamber of Commerce to provide newcomers to the county with information about the Conservation District and what resources are available from them
- **All WCG participants** can share information with your neighbors about VSP and the Conservation District

Community Visioning: What would you like to see for the future of Wahkiakum County?

Mapping out a vision of what needs doing in the community, and **creating health assessments of each watershed** (e.g., habitat conditions, flows, concerns), including actions that could improve watershed resilience, were ideas raised throughout the Wahkiakum Common Ground workshop series. One way to help guide that vision is to refer to the ***Principles to Achieve Multi-Benefit Watershed Restoration*** created by Wahkiakum Common Ground in 2025.

Reflecting on the guiding principles and the presentations, site visits, and discussions we've had together, this group talked about which aspects of Wahkiakum's identity and character are most important to preserve:

- The love of place & strong volunteer culture
- Protection of natural beauty, resources, and landscape
- Rural culture and identity
- Balancing conservation with economic livelihoods and working-land traditions

Planning is already underway—or may happen in the future—that could build on the work of Wahkiakum Common Ground and help express a shared community vision:

- Planning for the Cowlitz-Wahkiakum Council of Governments Comprehensive Economic Development Strategy (CEDS) is underway
- County plans like the Shoreline Master Plan, Comprehensive Flood Hazard Mitigation Plan, and Natural Hazard Mitigation Plan (Washington counties are required by FEMA to maintain and update a Natural Hazard Mitigation Plan (NHMP) every five years to remain eligible for federal disaster mitigation and recovery grants.)

To improve the quality of life for current and future residents, participants identified the following changes and investments:

- Job creation, job training, and other forms of workforce development, particularly workforce development for green jobs
- Ensuring people understand the need for and the role of volunteerism in the county
- Investment in outdoor recreation and eco-tourism
- Investment in public schools and youth

Next steps:

- **Sam Shogren** will take what he's heard from Wahkiakum Common Ground to the regional planning process led by the Cowlitz-Wahkiakum Council of Governments (CWCOG) and their Comprehensive Economic Development Strategy (CEDS) planning and implementation process

Support the Chinook Indian Nation in their efforts to get federal recognition and seek their input on watershed restoration projects

Chairman Tony Johnson of the Chinook Indian Nation (CIN) presented to Wahkiakum Common Ground at the first workshop to provide the history of the Chinook Indian Nation and their fight for federal recognition. The tribe was briefly federally recognized after a long battle in 2001, but recognition was revoked in 2002. In the context of watershed restoration efforts, there is a substantial value to partnering with and consulting the Chinook Indian Nation. Their traditional knowledge and long history stewarding of the lands and waters are crucial for restoration and long-term management of ecosystems and economies. However, the Chinook Indian Nation is reliant on the federal government upholding its responsibility and properly seating the Tribe as the federally recognized community of the Lower Columbia region. This recognition will allow the Tribe to carefully and intentionally share thousands of years of expertise and resources to partners. The community can play an important role in increasing pressure for CIN restoration of recognition. There are many other benefits to CIN federal recognition:

- **Substantially increased employment opportunities** with competitive salaries and benefits, and significant benefits to the local economy across the board (natural resources and other industries)
- **Funding for medical and mental health support** in the community, including the addition of badly needed facilities
- **More resources available to the tribe to enhance resilience** (e.g., funding to move critical infrastructure outside the tsunami zone) as well as provide help for other community members to bolster against increased coastal risk
- Federal laws govern **the return of remains and artifacts from museums and other institutions**; some institutions will not return these to the CIN without federal recognition - this is a major injustice.
- **Increased capacity of the tribe to partner on restoration projects**, and stronger support for fish habitats and hatcheries, as well as innovate in the forestry sector.
- **Protection of fishing and hunting rights** and local resources that support the broader community who rely on these resources (i.e. create public hunting opportunities, and protect and manage populations to support hunting and fishing).

In addition to supporting the efforts of the CIN to obtain federal recognition, attendees of WCG were also invited to support CIN efforts to support a coalition consisting of the CIN, the Shoalwater Bay Tribe, Chehalis Tribe, and Cowlitz Indian Tribe to protect the CIN's usual and accustomed hunting and fishing grounds from claims by the Quinault Nation. Community members can support the Chinook Indian Nation by:

- Signing their petition for recognition: https://chinookjustice.org/petition/#takeAction
- Signing up for the CIN newsletter: https://chinooknation.org/mailing-list/
- Writing to legislators in Washington and Oregon in support of CIN: https://chinookjustice.org/write-letter/#takeAction
- Support the coalition of the CIN, Shoalwater Bay Tribe, Chehalis Tribe, and Cowlitz Indian Tribe
- Follow the CIN on Social Media -- Facebook: https://www.facebook.com/ChinookIndianNation; Instagram: https://www.instagram.com/everydaychinook/

Other ideas to raise awareness of this issue for people not a part of Wahkiakum Common Ground included:

- Increasing media attention, for example, with a column in the newspaper
- Publicizing and inviting people to meetings in support of the Chinook Indian Nation
- Provide opportunities for CIN to speak at existing meetings, such as Grange meetings

Create a publicly-accessible flow chart of the agencies and non-profits who are involved in watershed restoration and their roles

There are many different organizations and agencies involved in watershed restoration and management in Wahkiakum County, making it difficult for landowners to know whom to reach out to. Increasing public awareness of these organizations and their roles could help increase landowner participation in restoration. A flowchart would also help people make better referrals, which leads to happier landowners and higher levels of trust.

To advance this effort, attendees proposed drafting a map of conservation organization missions and services. Because the WCG steering committee already has access to a lot of information that would be used to create this flowchart, they will take on responsibility for creating it. The flowchart will include information such as:

- Roles & services offered (technical assistance, funding, planning)
- Types of projects supported
- Geographic focus
- Contact process/timeline
- And more!

Next steps:

- **Carrie Shofner, Sanpisa Sritrairat,** and **Andrea Mah** will lead this effort, starting with a list of organizations represented among attendees at Wahkiakum Common Ground
    - All **organization and agency representatives** who attended WCG may be contacted individually to provide more information to help create this map.
    - A draft version of the flowchart may be sent out to **all attendees** for their feedback/use